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FRIDAY  
21<sup>ST</sup> NOVEMBER, 2025

## PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

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OFFICIAL REPORT

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### CONTENTS

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VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 1]

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE— [Col. 2]

STATEMENTS —

(a) Government's Financial Policy, 2026— [Col. 41]

(b) Commemoration of World Fisheries Day, 2025— [Col. 143]

ADJOURNMENT — [Col. 156]

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THE  
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC  
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Friday, 21<sup>st</sup> November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,  
Parliament House, at 10:55 a.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,  
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR,  
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS  
AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I have in my hands the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 20<sup>th</sup> November, 2025 for correction.

Page 1...15—

Yes, Hon Member?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

The page under review, specifically, the item numbered 2(i), I pray that we delete the first word that comes before “Ahiafor” and insert the word “Bernard”.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, take note.

Page 16...19?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 20<sup>th</sup> November as presented and corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the item numbered 6— Presentation of the Business Statement for the sixth week.

Yes, Chairperson of the Business Committee?

**BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE**

**Chairperson of the Business Committee/Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga):** Mr Speaker, the Committee met yesterday, Thursday, 20<sup>th</sup> November, 2025 and arranged Business of the House for the Sixth Week ending Friday, 28<sup>th</sup> November, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its report as follows:

**Arrangement of Business**

**Formal Communications by the Speaker**

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

**Question(s)**

respond to Questions asked of them during the Week:

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following Ministers to

**No. of Question(s)**

|                                                              |                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| i. Minister for Education                                    | 7                |
| ii. Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reforms     | 3                |
| iii. Minister for Roads and Highways                         | 9                |
| iv. Trade, Agribusiness and Industry                         | 4                |
| v. Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment                  | 3                |
| vi. Minister of State in Charge of Government Communications | 2                |
| <b>Total Number of Questions</b>                             | <b><u>28</u></b> |

Mr Speaker, in all, six (6) Ministers are expected to attend upon the House to respond to Twenty-Eight (28) Questions during the Week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent – 3;      ii. Oral – 25

**Statements**

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policies. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

**Bills, Papers and Reports**

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those

of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

**Motions and Resolutions**

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the Week.

**Referrals at Committees**

Mr Speaker, attached is the list of pending referrals at Committee. Once again the Business Committee is reminding Chairpersons of Committees to expedite work on the referrals and

report to the House. A total of Two Hundred and Seventy-Six (276) referrals are pending before Twenty-Five (25) Committees for consideration and report to the House.

Chairpersons of Committees are hereby notified that with the exception of referrals made this Meeting, all other referrals are due for reporting to the House. In effect, these referrals have been at Committee for three or more months. This therefore is in contradiction of Order 267(4). Committees with such referrals are therefore expected to present the Reports for consideration by the House.

### **Sitting of the House on Mondays**

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee proposes that the House sits on Mondays commencing Monday, 24<sup>th</sup> November, 2025. This is to afford the House ample time to schedule pending Questions and Statements.

### **Commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government**

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 195(3) the Business Committee is reminding Hon Members that the commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government which commenced on Tuesday, 18<sup>th</sup> November, 2025 will continue on Tuesday, 25<sup>th</sup> November. The Majority and Minority Leaders will conclude the commentary on Wednesday, 26<sup>th</sup> November.

### **Submission of Budget Estimates**

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee continues to entreat the Ministry of Finance, other Ministries and Independent Constitutional Bodies to submit estimates to the House timeously for the consideration and approval.

### **Conclusion**

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216(2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the Week.

### **Monday, 24<sup>th</sup> November, 2025**

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

(a) **Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah (Garu):** To make a Statement on closing the Physician Gap in Ghana – Global Perspectives and Strategic Options.

(b) **Dr Stephen Amoah (Nhyiaeso):** To make a Statement on making Entrepreneurship part of Ghana's Basic and SHS Academic Curricula.

(c) **Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East):** To make a Statement on the Challenges of the Cashew Industry in Ghana.

(d) **Mr Solomon Kuyon (Krachi Nchumuru):** To make a Statement on the urgent need for a National Youth Development Fund.

(e) **Mr Bismark Tetteh Nyarko (Upper Manya Krobo):** To make a Statement on the Commemoration of the Annual Ngmayem Festival Celebrated by the Chiefs and People of Manya Klo Traditional Area, to be Held from 27<sup>th</sup> October to 1<sup>st</sup> of November.

(f) **Mr Eric Edem Agbana (Ketu North):** To make a Statement on the need to upgrade the Ohawu Agricultural College into a fully-fledged Agricultural University.

(g) **Ms Laurette Korkor Asante (Atiwa West):** To make a Statement on Emergency Care in Ghana; A Lack Thereof.

(h) **Mr Ntebe Ayo William (Tatale-Sanguli):** To make a Statement on the poor demarcation of electoral boundaries and overcrowded polling stations as root causes of election disputes in Ghana.

(i) **Mr Charles Asiedu (Tano South):** To make a Statement on the Urgent need to revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company Limited.

(j) **Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (Evalue Ajomoro Gwira):** To make a Statement on the State of Housing in Ghana and the need for a National Affordable Housing Fund Act.

Questions

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Committee Sitings

**Tuesday, 25<sup>th</sup> November, 2025**

Roll Call

Statements

(a) The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government for the year ending 31<sup>st</sup> December 2026.

*- Commentary to continue*

(b) **Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (Old Tafo):** To make a Statement on the urgent need to prioritise and invest in Ghana's Boxing.

(c) **Mr Eric Edem Agbana, (Ketu North):** to make a Statement on population and development: Shaping Ghana's Development.

(d) **Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (Offinso North):** to make a Statement on the persistent and escalating threat of Highway Robbery on our roads in Ghana.

(e) **Ms Dorcas Afo Toffey (Jomoro):** to make a Statement on addressing violence against Women and Girls.

Urgent Questions

(a) **Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (Okaikwei Central):** To ask the Minister for Education what measures the Ministry is implementing to finance the upcoming end-of-academic-year examination in public basic schools and prevent the charging of exams fees.

(b) **Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (Pru East):** To ask the Minister for Education, measures the Ministry has implemented to prevent examination malpractices and cancellation of examination papers, especially in BECE and WASSCE, considering the negative impact, such cancellation have had on students of my Constituency in the previous years.

(c) **Mr Charles Forson (Tema Central):** To ask the Minister for Education the steps the Ministry is taking to curb the use of fake education credentials such as PhD among others.

#### Questions

**\*179. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Education update on the stalled Sempe School Project in Odododiodioo and the reasons for the delay.

**\*218. Mr Fred Kyei Asamoah (Offinso North):** To ask the Minister for Education the steps being implemented to ensure prompt payment of the 2025 book and research allowance to members of the Teacher Unions.

**\*219. Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah (Afigya Kwabre North):** To ask the Minister of Education when the GETFund-sponsored classroom block at St Michael's Senior High School will be completed at Ahenkro.

**\*220. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (Aha Ano South West):** To ask the Minister for Education about the stance of the Ministry on the refusal of

the Chairman of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in the Ahafo Ano South West Constituency to commission a safe and prepared educational facility (Mankranso Methodist KG Block) as well as the suitable interventions being implemented to ensure that the school children are not further deprived.

**\*236. Ms Gloria Owusu (Trobu):** To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reforms what specific reforms the Ministry is implementing to improve efficiency, transparency and accountability.

**\*249. Mr Samuel Awuku (Akwapim North):** To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reforms what steps are being taken to digitise public services and reduce bureaucratic delays at key government agencies.

**\*500. Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):** To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reform how the Public Records and Archives Administration Department (PRAAD) digitisation of 55,259 archival sheets and disposal of 8,540 boxes is improving records management, efficiency and what resources have been allocated for further digitisation in 2025.

#### Presentation of Papers

#### Motions

#### Consideration Stage

• Ghana Deposit Protection  
(Amendment) Bill, 2025

## Committee Sitings

**Wednesday, 26<sup>th</sup> November, 2025**

## Roll Call

## Statements

(a) The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government for the year ending 31<sup>st</sup> December, 2026.

- *Commentary to conclude*

(b) **Mr Seidu Haruna (Wenchi)**: To make a Statement on motivating the youth as a tool to boost agriculture under the Feed Ghana Initiative.

(c) **Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor, (South Tongu)**: to make a Statement on the improper installation and alignment of Utility Infrastructure

(d) **Mr Issah Salifu Taylor (Tarkua Nsuaem)**: to make a Statement on the use of Solar-Powered Street Lights for Energy Sustainability

(e) **Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (Anyaa Sowutuom)**: to make a Statement on broken Traffic Lights and Pedestrian Safety in Ghana.

## Questions

**\*377. Mr Yao Gomado (Akan)**: To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when work will commence on the following areas in the Kadjebi District, since the Feeder Department completed the survey and mapping years ago: (i) Dodi-Papase to Dodo-Pepesu (ii) Dodo-

Amanfrom to Daapa Junction (iii) Asato to Wawaso (iv) Koto-Nkwanta to Titiaka (v) Koto-Nkwanta to Sabram

**\*453. Mr Yao Gomado (Akan)** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads will be fixed: (i) Dodo – Olobi to Okrakrom (Koru) (ii) Akposokodzi Township Kadjebi road.

**\*455. Mr Sanja Nanja (Atebubu/Amantin)**: To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways what immediate measures the Ministry is implementing to fix the potholes on the Amantin and the Yeji stretch of the Kumasi-Yeji Highway to prevent further deterioration of the road.

**\*380. Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (South Tongu)**: To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the government is going to renovate the Sogakope Bridge (Lower Volta Bridge), especially the expansion gaps and the metal railings.

**\*381. Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (South Tongu)**: To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of work on the Agave-Afedume road and when work will commence on site.

**\*476. Mr Kwabena Boateng (Ejisu)**: To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of the Ejisu-Onwe-Assieninpong-Kwaso road in the Ejisu Constituency and when work will resume to complete the road.

**\*512. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South)**: To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the



construction of the following abandoned roads will be resumed and completed (i) Maakro – Agogo- Twedie (ii) Supreme Saviour – Canaan.

**\*516. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction of the following abandoned roads will be resumed and completed: (i) Bosankro Junction – Bosankro (ii) Akuapim Junction – Akuapim.

**\*517. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction works will resume on the following roads: (i) Wiosu – Amanchia (ii) Nkawie – Nkran Foase (iii) Ntabanum Junction – Ntabanum.

**\*515. Mr Charles Forson (Tema Central):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the contractor for the Community 9 Light Industrial Area Road network will return to site.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Committee Sittings

**Thursday, 27<sup>th</sup> November, 2025**

Roll Call

Statements

(a) **Mr Sebastian Deh (Kpando):** to make a Statement on supporting Smallholder Farmers in Ghana- The role

of Financial inclusion with tailor-made Innovative Financial Products.

(b) **Dr Mahama Tiah Abdul-Kabiru (Walewale):** to make a Statement on the decline of youth Financing from the District Assembly Common Fund (DACF) to the National Youth Authority (NYA) and the Youth Employment Agency (YEA)

(c) **Mr Davis Ansah Opoku (Mpreaso) and Mr Abed-Nego Bandim (Bunkprugu)** to make a joint Statement on strengthening key institutions to drive Ghana's Digital Transformation and Inclusion: Lessons from participating in the Giz-Supported Tech Policy Fellowship.

(d) **Mr Issah Atta (Sagnarigu):** To make a Statement on opportunities for trade facilitation within and among African countries: challenges, weaknesses, and the way forward.

Questions

**\*286. Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (Offinso South):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the status of the Komenda Sugar Factory.

**\*315. Mr Michael Okyere Baafi (New Juaben South):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the status of the vehicle component manufacturing policy.

**\*316. Prof Kingsley Nyarko (Kwadaso):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the specific interventions the Ministry has taken to stimulate domestic production,

increase export volumes and add value to our products to boost trade earnings.

**\*401. Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang – Lower Denkyira):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the plans of the Ministry to increase exports to take advantage of the current cedi performance as well as increase the share of the trade sector to Ghana's GDP.

#### Motions

#### Private Members' Motion

- That this Honourable House inquiries into the effectiveness of the policies and regulations governing Ghana extractive sectors and how to better regulate the sector to enhance national development and benefit.

#### Committee Sittings

**Friday, 28<sup>th</sup> November, 2025**

#### Roll Call

#### Statements

(a) **Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (Old Tafo)** to make a Statement on the need to prioritise the completion and optimal utilisation of existing Sports Infrastructure before initiating New Projects.

(b) **Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu (Ho Central)** to make a Statement on the UHAS Leads Ghana in Global Impact Rankings- A Beacon of Health, Innovation and Development.

(c) **Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (Kintampo North):** to make a Statement on the urgent call to establish a Health Security Fund for Ghana.

(d) **Ms Dorcas Afo Toffey (Jomoro):** To make a Statement on the Economic Empowerment and Financial Literacy of Women.

#### Questions

**\*470. Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what proactive measures the Ministry is taking on labour upheavals that has become rife lately in the country.

**\*503. Mr Tweneboah Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what the Ministry is using to track employment growth and if these targets area being met.

**\*504. Mr Tweneboah Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what is being done to improve occupational health and safety standards, especially in high-risk industries like construction and mining.

**\*535. Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (Nsawam-Adoagyiri):** To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Government Communications the full details of the Government Advisory Council which was set up upon the invitation of the President to representatives of Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) in Ghana, and

what this auxiliary body is costing the taxpayer.

**\*96. Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (Old Tafo):** To ask the Minister of State in charge of Government Communication the total cost of all committees formed by the President and Ministers and the sources of funds since the expenditure was not included in the first-quarter budget approved by Parliament.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Committee Sittings

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** We indicated in the copy of the Business Statement before you, that we might sit on Monsay. But I would want to indicate that there is not agreement on that yet. So, I can say authoritatively that we would not sit on Monday. So we would not sit on Monday but on Tuesday.

11:05 a.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Business Statement has been ably presented. It is now for your comments.

Yes, Rev John Ntim Fordjour?

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, this is the Business of the House for the Sixth Week of the Third Meeting of this Ninth Parliament and it has been six weeks since the

Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill, which is a Private Members Bill, was featured on the *Order Paper*. The next day, it was removed and some disputed reasons were given. A week after, the Speaker of Parliament gave a ruling, in the records, *Hansard* captured it, that nothing prevents the Bill from being laid. It has been five weeks from the time that Mr Speaker gave that ruling. Since then, no attempt has been made by this House to have the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill to deal with the canker of LGBTQ, devastating our norms and culture in this country, threatening our family values. There seems to be a very conspicuous silence on this.

Mr Speaker, the House must not create an impression that what was a priority in the Eighth Parliament, a priority to the 275 Members of Parliament, has suddenly been thrown under the carpet and has suddenly been jettisoned by the Ninth Parliament. We have debated it and concluded. The controversy was resolved. The Rt Hon Speaker declared that the Bill has to be featured on the *Order Paper*. So, the attempt by this Government, to block this Bill from being featured, is a big disappointment to the people of this country. To the over 93 per cent of Ghanaians who believe that marriage is between man and woman. It is a big disappointment to them.

Mr Speaker, we demand that if it was oversight or error, it must be added to the *Order Paper* so that next week it is laid and presented for First Reading because on record, it has satisfied all the

processes by the dictates of our Standing Orders and has been duly approved to be presented, laid for first reading and consequential referrals.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

**Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh):** Mr Speaker, thank you. Let me thank the Leader of the House for his presentation. I heard the Leader making an appeal that Estimates expected to be brought to this House should be brought timeously for our Committees to do justice as we move towards the consideration of the Estimates. As of my last check, I was informed that we have received 15 of the Estimates so far. Let me commend the Chief Whip for that. I am quite aware of the cycle as to how these matters have been dealt with over the years; 15 Estimates so far is quite good.

However, that is 15 out of about 41. So, there is still more. I want to appeal to the Leader of the House that he should add his voice so that we can get as many as possible, because the Estimates have also contributed to the delay in the consideration of the Motions on the Floor.

That will be it for now and you know it has its impact on rising, so that we do not sit deep into the night.

Mr Speaker, I see that there are over 290 referrals, and I can sympathise with the Majority Leader, but we cannot put the blame on him. Those of us in Leadership must extend a hand to help. I

suggested this advertisement of the referrals, but clearly it is not helping. I do not see it helping in any significant way. Now that the Committees would be considering Estimates, we are worse off. So, the earlier referrals are potentially going to suffer, because for the next two weeks or more, the focus and the priority of the Committees will be the Estimates. So, Majority Leader, with all due respect, I want to suggest maybe Leadership should meet, we cannot leave all this in your hands alone. Both Sides should meet the Committee heads, or those who have these referrals outstanding. Then we can probably get innovative on how we can deal with it.

Mr Speaker, these matters are straightforward and we cannot belabour the point on Monday Sitting. The Majority Leader has already explained why we have to suspend the earlier idea of Sitting. I thought it was a good idea, but we would defer to him.

Mr Speaker, I am worried about a phenomenon and I say this without any malice. Early on, about a month ago, I had raised this matter on the floor of the House, that following the devastation to our environment, we are reading all sorts of Reports, water bodies, even food from the farm being poisoned with heavy metals among others. I humbly suggested earlier that if it pleases this House and the Business Committee, to do something beyond the ordinary, can we not reprogram the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, now that these matters are escalating and taking a serious direction? Can the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources not brief us

every week? Let us know what is happening and I say this without malice. I say that with a pure sense of patriotism, that as Ghanaians, as representatives of the people—I see the Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources is well and exceptionally dressed today.

Mr Speaker, he is coming to debate. I hope he will give us solutions to *galamsey*. That is just by the way. So, I want to appeal. I beg this House, let us resolve for once. This is not a partisan matter. The waters are poisoned, even food on our table is getting poisoned by heavy metals. So, I am simply saying, Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, and with the blessings of the other Side of the House—Hon Samuel Atta Mills, I know you support me on this—let us programme the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. I am not saying specifically the substantive Minister himself; the Deputy Minister is capable. He can come and brief us. Every week, they should come and tell us, where we are and how the fight is going. Are there things that we should do as a House to support them? This is very important and I pray that it is not taken out of context. *Galamsey* is putting our lives at risk. Even food from our farms is at risk.

Mr Speaker, having said that, let me conclude on the referrals again. 290 referrals are not ordinary and there must be a reason why these matters are still outstanding. Hon Majority Leader, as I said, we must also contribute to resolving this challenge and we on this Side would be glad to heed to a call from you for us to meet together as a

Leadership to find a way of resolving this matter.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah?

**Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah:** Mr Speaker, thank you. I would like to draw the Chairman of the Business Committee's attention to Standing Order 221(1). It is with regard to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation and the referrals there under Paragraph 16 of the Attachment. Hon Majority Leader, our Committee is supposed to present our Reports after the referrals have been made to us per the rules at least five Sitting days before the expiration of the 21 Sitting days in accordance with Article 11(7). So, we are not in any way in breach of the rules of the House. I just wanted to bring it to your attention.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources?

**Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Alhaji Yusif Sulemana):** Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make few comments with respect to the Business Statement. I want to join my Colleague, Rev Ntim Fordjour, to call for the need for us to begin the conversation on the Human Sexual and Family Values Bill, 2024. But I want to also suggest that as much as possible we do not politicise this

issue once again. We are here today because somebody did not do what he was supposed to do, and I thought my Brother would have pointed it out. The former President was the one to sign this Bill into an Act. It was complete; it was ready —*[Interruption]*

11:15 a.m.

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour** — *rose* —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, kindly hold on.

Yes, Rev Ntim Fordjour, why are you up?

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, my good Friend and Brother, Hon—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Why are you interrupting? What is the basis of your interruption?

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, I rise on Standing Order 123(2)—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What does Order 123(2) say?

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, the comment my Hon Colleague just raised is not accurate. If he has a concern which is genuine, he has to go straight to the point and join the call. But bringing in extraneous matters which are not accurate, and blaming the former President—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, you are completely out of order, kindly resume your seat.

Alhaji Sulemana, you have the floor.

**Alhaji Y. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, I am grateful. I am adding my voice to what he said, but I am also cautioning that there is a need for us not to politicise this issue. And I just want to point out that this Bill by now should have been an Act, if some other people had acted. So, for me, let us move away from trying to politicise this issue. The President, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, a few days ago, made his position very clear on this matter, that as soon as the Bill is ready, he was not going to use any means to frustrate the process of signing it, and that he was going to sign it. So, let us work together to ensure that this Bill is put together very well, and we will now have a President who is ready to sign it.

My second issue also has to do with the call on the Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to come here frequently to brief this House. My Hon Minister has just asked me to tell the House that we are more than ready to come and respond to your issues. I know my Hon Minister has also had some conversations with the Leadership, so I will pause here, and my able Leader will complete the records.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Is there any further comment?

Yes, Hon Comfort Doyoe?

**Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe:** Mr Speaker, I would like to plead with the House, to let the Hon Minister

reintroduce the Songor Lagoon Bill in the House, so that we can solve the Songor Lagoon issue once and for all. Mr Speaker, people are always agitating in Ada and there are beatings, demonstrations and other things going on. We cannot breathe; we cannot rest. So, if we can reintroduce it or the Hon Minister could come and brief the House on what he has been able to do so far. So that we solve it. It can be solved for McDan to have his peace to work and the good people of Ada can also have their peace in the community.

So, Mr Speaker, please, on the Songor Lagoon issue, the Hon Minister should come and do the briefing.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker let me thank the Chairman of the Business Committee, and in all humility, appeal to him that since the commentary on the Budget will continue next week, Tuesday, if he and Leadership took the decision on time allocation, if they could just prop up the baseline time, which is five minutes, to about seven or eight minutes, so that at least we can elicit more substantial responses from those of us who are attempting for the first time.

Thank you so much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader, any further comment?

*[The Hon Minority Leader gestured to indicate he has no comment]*

Yes, Hon Majority Leader and Chairman of the Business Committee, your response to the comment?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, as the records of this House will testify, the Government of President John Dramani Mahama and the NDC Majority, and I believe the Rt Hon Speaker, we are all very committed to the passage of the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill, 2024. If we would recall, a couple of weeks ago when we debated this, I was the person who insisted that the fastest way to have this passed into law was to take a position that this Parliament has already passed it. So, what is left is the signature, and I recall many on their Side arguing against my position, so the Speaker ruled. He ruled that so far as he is concerned, the life of the Eighth Parliament had elapsed, and this is a new Parliament. And once it was not signed, it had to be reintroduced afresh and taken through all the Stages. So, if they had listened to my advice and sided with me in the debate in this House, that we should treat it as having been passed by this House, and that once it is passed by this House, it is not part of Businesses that have elapsed, by now, we would have left it squarely in the hands of the Presidency to sign. But because I did not get that support from them, the position became that it has not been passed, so we must take it through all these processes.

So, if there is anybody committed to this legislation being passed, especially to have it passed expeditiously, clearly, it is me and the people on this Side. We have decided that it should be freshly

considered by this House, and the Speaker indicated that it is going through the mill and will come back to this House. So it is not an attempt by Government, and President John Dramani Mahama has indicated time and again, that any moment that the Bill is brought before him, he will expeditiously sign it.

So, my Hon Colleague, Rev Ntim Fordjour, even though in the Eighth Parliament, I really did not see him actively involved in having this Bill passed. I know he was a sponsor of the Bill, but as we considered it, I did not really see much of his involvement. If we would recall, it was my Committee that it was referred to, and I did not see much of his personal involvement. So, I am surprised that all of a sudden, he thinks that this is an urgent matter that must engage a priority in terms of the work of this House. Also, when we were all putting pressure on former President Akufo-Addo to sign, I did not see him helping us to put up that pressure on the former President. I did not see him resisting, and now he has found his voice, and thinks President John Dramani Mahama or the NDC is conspiring not to have the Bill introduced and passed.

I can assure him that we are very committed to having the Bill introduced and passed. Indeed, the estimates are coming, and we will keep mounting pressure. I know that the 21 Sitting days have not elapsed, but we also know that once the 21 Sitting days have elapsed, even if we bring a report recommending to this House that we should not allow it to come into force, we do not have any capacity to change it. So, I believe that it

is better that the Subsidiary Legislation Committee presents the report before the expiry of the 21 Sitting days. This is because if it expires, we cannot change it; it becomes law. So, I agree with the Hon Member that we still have some days, but the practice should be that they bring it before the 21 Sitting days expire.

11:25 p.m.

On *galamsey*, I believe the Minister is ready and willing at all times to come and brief us on the progress being made. I can testify that a lot of work is going on, a lot of equipment that would have aggravated the situation have been seized, excavators too have been seized. It has become next to impossible to import excavators into this country. I have been approached by even road contractors, who have legitimate road construction contracts from Government, and they are having a difficulty even getting permission from Government to import, specifically, excavators for the purposes of their road construction projects, because Government is keen on limiting the influx of excavators into our country.

Indeed, for those who do not really understand the *galamsey* menace, like I said, since colonial times, artisanal mining has been happening in this country. But what aggravated and created the vast expanse of excavations across the country for the purposes of small-scale mining has been the introduction of excavators into the country. The sponsorship that came from our Chinese brothers and sisters, and the involvement of political party kingpins



in trying very hard to get governments to compromise and allow them to carry out these operations. If we look at the activity of this Government, in these three areas, clearly, no one can question the amount of work that has gone into stopping the excavations. So, no more excavators are allowed to come into the country. Those excavators out there have been seized and efforts are ongoing to permanently confiscate them. So, we do not see the level of excavations that used to happen.

But I am the first to admit that at the artisanal level, we still have young people out there with their pickaxes and their shovels, digging and trying to find some gold. But that level of damage is not what we should really be worried about. So, that attempt to create an impression that *galamsey* is happening and nothing is being done about it—I agree that we are not reclaiming. So, anybody driving will see a lot of open pits along the roads and highways. But that is not digging that took place in the last nine months. If one is flying an aircraft from here to Kumasi, and looks out through the window, we would see vast areas of excavations between Accra and Kumasi, in the Eastern Region and some portions of Ashanti Region.

But these are not excavations that happened in the last eight months. These are excavations that have happened for the last 12 to 15 years. Because we have not filled those pits, when we are still driving around, we see it. So, we must admit that a lot of work has gone in, unlike in the past where reports were brought by Ministers showing that

government officials are aiding and abetting. Today, any government official found to be aiding and abetting will be arrested. Any party official, no matter how high, whether at the national level or regional level, if caught, would not have the President say anything. He will allow the due process of the law to deal with the person. A mere allegation against someone is creating a problem. Even a Member of this House who is alleged to have obstructed the enforcement of the ban was arrested and arraigned before the courts.

So, I can say that when it comes to the commitment to fight *galamsey* as a menace, the track record of this Government is unparalleled. So, we are ready and we believe that they are mentioning the name because this Government has taken action. Unlike in the past when certain regional chairmen were known to be openly involved in *galamsey*—Government appointees and even the minister wrote a report, but nothing happened about the report, and journalists videotaped people and exposed them, but nothing happened. In this Government, just bring the evidence and this Government will deal with that person ruthlessly. Mr Speaker, the Minister will come as often as we want him to brief this House.

On the Songor Lagoon issue, I think we can ask Urgent Questions and the relevant sector Minister will come and brief this House as to exactly what is happening.

I believe that we have not really changed anything on the time allocated

for commentary. It has always been the practice in this House that Leadership, Chairpersons and Ranking Members have more time than Backbenchers, *et cetera* and that is exactly what has been repeated. I think the problem is what I raised at the beginning of this Parliament, which is the disproportionate allocation of time between the Minority and the Majority. Why do I say so? We have 87 people on the Minority Side and we have 189 on the Majority Side. So, when we say equal numbers, during the debate, one person speaks from the Majority Side, then one person speaks on the Minority Side. By the time we finish, if we have 87 from each Side speak, we will still have over 100 on the Majority Side who have not had the opportunity.

So, yes, I agree that it is not about the content; it is about the opportunity we give to Backbenchers. That is why from the beginning I argued in this House that given the vast difference in the numbers, if we stick to the principle that we are two Sides, therefore, must be given equal time in any debate, yes, substance-wise it may not matter, but in terms of opportunity to participate, the people on the Majority Side of the House will be unfairly treated and it is beginning to manifest. So, I think that we must revisit that issue so that we take two on the Majority Side then one on the Minority Side, so that when 10 people speak on the Minority Side, 20 people on the Majority Side will get to speak.

This is so that as many Backbenchers on the Majority side will have the opportunity to also have a bite. So, that is an appeal that I want to make to the

Speaker because this is a ruling of the Speaker and by our Standing Orders, unless I come by a Motion to challenge it, but I am not willing to challenge Mr Speaker's ruling. But this is just to appeal that even as he enforces the ruling—I recall the Speaker said it is subject to the discretion of the Speaker, so maybe, if the Rt Hon Speaker will exercise his discretion and allocate more speaking opportunities to the Majority so that many of our Members and Backbenchers can also have a bite during the period of the commentary. It would help us reduce some of the pressure on my good self.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

11:35 a.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But Hon Minority Chief Whip, I asked specifically whether there is a further comment, and you said no.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, with respect, my commentary is coming as a result of the response of the Leader of the House.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, let me say that on the matter of *galamsey*, it is important we contextualise it. I am not calling for the Minister to just come one-off and read Statements and go back to the Ministry. No, I am calling for the Minister to be here every week. Leader, we listened to you in silence. You said that as many times as possible, the Minister would come. Yes, if you concede to the fact that the fight is becoming difficult.

Mr Speaker, I heard him when he was talking about *galamsey*, and he mentioned that when we sit in a plane, the aerial view shows there is demolition all over in the country. There is a singular litmus test. If the water bodies are getting bad, if our lands are getting destroyed, and now, under your watch—listen to me. I am saying it is not about the excavators anymore. That is just a microscopic aspect of the entire problem.

Mr Speaker, the best litmus test is how the land is; our farmlands are being destroyed, our water bodies are being destroyed, and all major water bodies in this country are getting bad. We are even being told by scientific reports that heavy metals are found in food from the farms. That cannot be a good test. So, I am saying that if we are adopting the Report, let us adopt the Business Statement appropriately. I am saying that the Minister should not just come and read one one-off Statement and go back. No. Every week, he should be here.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** When the Chairman of the Business Committee said, as often, what does that mean?

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** That can be interpreted to mean anything. I am saying that we should adopt a position that every week, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** It can even be twice in a week.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Yes, that is fine. But I wanted—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Because the word he used is; as often.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Yes. But I am saying that he should come at least once every week and I am not calling for the Minister himself. The Deputy Minister can come and do that. I want us to set that matter clear. Also, I am saying that this matter about the number of excavators imported is neither here nor there. If the water bodies are bad, and we are finding heavy metals in our foodstuffs from the farm, and you tell me you are fighting *galamsey*, then you have failed. I see him struggling to justify. He should let the Minister come and speak to the people's representative.

Mr Speaker, the matter of disproportionate speakers is neither here nor there. The Leader and the Majority leadership should get innovative. What we have done, maybe you should learn from us. We have a wonderful blend of the old Members of Parliament and the first-time Members. we have done a wonderful blend. He should be taking a cue from the opposition. His Backbenchers are all complaining. Why? Because he is not fulfilling them. We have trained our first-time Members of Parliament, and they are ready to do justice. Now they are complaining. Where are his people? They have 187 Members of Parliament, but they have empty seats. His Side is empty.

Mr Speaker, we are simply saying that what the Majority Leader is proposing is alien to parliamentary jurisprudence. There is nowhere in the world where it is said that five people

should speak from the Majority Side and one person should speak from the Minority Side. The Speaker has settled this matter, and I am happy that at Conclave, you gave wise counsel that Leadership should relate. They should not come and create problems for you. Leadership should relate to the Speaker. The Speaker has ruled on this matter, and he rightly observed that he knows what to do if he wants to challenge the speakers. They cannot appeal to us; we would not accept any appeal from them. The status quo remains.

If he wants to challenge the ruling of the Speaker, as experienced as he is, he should come by a Motion, and we would face him on that Motion. They should do a wonderful blend; they need to find a way to blend their Colleagues.

Mr Speaker, on *galamsey*, no matter what they say, the people of this country would not be convinced, especially when the water bodies are bad—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, can we talk about the Business Statement?

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, my commentary is coming out of his answers. He spoke for about 10 minutes as if he was the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. He spoke authoritatively on *galamsey*. Meanwhile, he is not at the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources. I do not know if *galamsey* is happening in his backyard. There is no *galamsey* in his backyard. For those of us who have been affected, let us speak, because our future is on the line.

I want the House to adopt that the Minister of Lands and Natural Resources must be here, and we must give them a template. They just cannot come and read speeches and just go away. In this House, the Leadership must give a template on what they have to come and speak to. They cannot just come and read long-winding speeches and just walk away and say that they are fighting *galamsey*. Is that how to fight *galamsey*? Show by competence; the turbidity level of the water must change. That is only when we can say that they are doing well.

Mr Speaker, without adding more, I want to say that we should adopt the position that a minimum of once a week, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources must appear.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Unfortunately, you are not in charge of programming Government Business, so it is a suggestion that you are making.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, I beg you; can I just finish? Majority Leader, sit down, I have not finished. If I have said something untoward, he can get up and catch the eye of the Speaker. I am saying that on the issue of *galamsey*, they have failed and they are failing.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Mr Annoh-Dompreh, you are a Member of the Business Committee.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Yes. I cannot programme all by myself.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well, then, you are done.

Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, this House has 43 Committees. The Committees are led by Chairpersons and Ranking Members. The Chairpersons have deputies, and the Ranking Members, also have deputies.

Mr Speaker, the Minority Side has only 87 Members. By virtue of being only 87, if they are to choose the Leadership of Committees, invariably, they have 86 Members who would be Leaders. Because one is Chairperson, the other is either a Ranking Member or a Deputy Ranking Member. So, in the process, almost, you know, all of them would end up being in the Leadership of Committees, and the time allocation gives the Leadership of Committees more time than Backbenchers. So, there is nothing innovative that they are doing. It is not innovative. He cannot say that the Majority Side should learn from them and that they should be innovative. If innovation is depleting your numbers in this Chamber, we prefer to remain the Majority and not be speaking. They cannot deplete your numbers and say you are innovative. Because that is what has led to this situation where almost every one of them gets to speak for ten minutes because almost everybody is either a Ranking Member or a Deputy Ranking Member or even a Chairperson of your Committee.

11:45 a.m.

There is nothing innovative that they are doing. So, they should not tell me that the Majority Side should learn and be

innovative like them. Mr Speaker, well, I am in the Despatch box, but he has brought it on to all of us.

As for the issue of *galamsey*, I know that in communication, part of the trick is to continue repeating a lie for so many times, and it might be confused as being the truth. I understand that that is part of communication. But the truth of the matter is that everybody in this country knows that this Government is fighting *galamsey*, and everybody knows that we inherited a very bad situation when *galamsey* was not being fought. It was a free-for-all affair with excavators everywhere. Indeed, the Minister for Environment, Science, Technology and Innovation under President Akufo-Addo, under the NPP, publicly indicated the involvement of senior government officials in *galamsey* activities in forests and everywhere. So, they cannot come today and pretend that *galamsey* started eight months ago. And they cannot say that the pollution of water bodies occurred eight months ago. It will take time to extract the heavy metals that polluted those areas because of the excavations that they did. Indeed, it will be difficult to extract some of the metals.

So, he cannot all of a sudden expect that within eight months, all the heavy metals that have been poured at the *galamsey* site for eight years will all of a sudden just vanish. It requires huge investments. As we speak, Government is taking steps to reclaim those areas. So, I can assure them that this whole claim that, if foodstuff today have traces of mercury in them, can they ask themselves when was that particular item

was planted? How long did it take to harvest that item? Any food on the market must have been planted six months ago, and harvested and processed at least three months ago and are now on the market. So, it cannot be *galamsey* that occurred in the last six months that has polluted the water bodies to create a situation where food stuffs are contaminated. This is work that they did that caused the pollution, and we are trying to fix it. So, they should support us.

As for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources coming here every week or twice in a week, they are asking the Minister to go out there and fight *galamsey*, now they are asking him to leave the fight and come and be briefing them. So, what is the Minister expected to do; to be here every day briefing this House or to be on the field fighting *galamsey*? Which one do you want? Are they saying that the Minister should stop the fight out there on the field? Is *galamsey* happening in this Chamber? Why should the Minister spend most of his time in this Chamber briefing this House on *galamsey* instead of being on the field fighting *galamsey*?

So, Mr Speaker, let me conclude by indicating that, as for the Minister, any time that a Question is asked of him regarding *galamsey* activities, I can assure them that the Minister will come and answer the Questions and brief the House. I also want to plead that this arrangement of speaking allocation and proportionality should be reconsidered because the Backbenchers on this Side have really been deprived of some opportunity that Backbenchers on the

Minority Side are enjoying. I just want us to be fair. It is not on all issues that I would say it should be two to one. But when it comes to commentary on the Budget, *[Interruption]* Well, there is only one Minority Leader and one Majority Leader. But we have so many Backbenchers here and very few Backbenchers there. That is why we are asking for proportionality.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Business Statement as presented is hereby adopted.

Hon Members, the item numbered 7.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, I wish to find out, just for clarification, which position has this House adopted on the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources coming to brief the House? Is it the case that we are saying that he can come on an inception of a Question or on my call that every week he should be here once? What is the position now?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, we all understand the word ‘often’, and I will still stick to the meaning of the word ‘often’.

Hon Members, item numbered 7, the commentary on the Statement by the Hon Minister for Finance on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government for the year ending 31<sup>st</sup> December 2026. First on my list is Hon Yusif Sulemana. Hon Member, you are speaking for 15 minutes. You have the floor.

## STATEMENT

### Government's Financial Policy, 2026

*[Resumption of commentary from 20/11/25]*

**Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi):** Mr Speaker, God bless you.

Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the item numbered 7(a), which is before us this morning. Before I go to the substantive issues of land and natural resources, I would like to make some corrections to some comments that were made a few days ago, especially coming from my good Friend, Hon Alexander Akwasi Acquah, who is here. He tried to compare the former President, H. E. Nana Akufo-Addo, with H. E. John Dramani Mahama. I want to make an appeal that Nana Akufo-Addo is on retirement, and so it would be appropriate to allow him to enjoy his peace. The way and manner he always brings him up for debate, I do not know whether it is deliberate to expose him the more.

Mr Speaker, we had a President who abandoned a lot of projects. He abandoned Bole Town Roads. He abandoned all projects that were going on at the Bole Senior High School. He abandoned the Bole-Bamboi road. He abandoned the teacher training college that was started in 2016. Indeed, he abandoned Bole personally. Why do I say so? For the eight years that he became President, he never visited Bole. We invited him several times, he did not

go. Now he wants to compare him with H. E. John Dramani Mahama. If President John Dramani Mahama has not done anything for the people of Kyebi, he provided them with potable water when indeed they were— [Expunged by the order of the Speaker] That is what His Excellency John Dramani Mahama has done. So as much as possible, Hon Alexander Acquah should not provoke this kind of debate.

Mr Speaker, now to the issue of the hospital that he referred to, this hospital was built by the former President, Ignatius Kutu Acheampong.

The hospital saw renovation almost under every administration, except the Nana Akufo-Addo administration. It was abandoned to the extent that the current President of Ghana, who was in opposition, had to rush with his wife to go and build a maternity ward.

**Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh — rose**

11:55 a.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please stop the time for Hon Sulemana.

Hon Minority Chief Whip and Hon Members, today and thereafter, we shall go strictly in accordance with the rules. So, you can now tell me why you are up.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I would not do this. I intended to listen to my Colleague, but a while ago, he made a definite statement that the people of Kyebi—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Satisfy the rules.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, I am coming under Order 123 (2a) and by extension, even 2(b). It is still applicable.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What is the offensive word?

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** He said that the people of Kyebi were drinking water with pigs. He made that definite statement, and granted that he wants to stand by that, then, he must provide evidence for that statement. Otherwise, he must be made to withdraw, and Mr Speaker, that aspect of his speech must be expunged, and he must apologise to the good people of Kyebi and the people of Eastern Region. That is offensive.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Accordingly, I direct that that be expunged from the record. Please, you have the floor.

**Alhaji Y. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, I am grateful.

Mr Speaker, the people of Kyebi are my friends, and I did not intend to say anything that would incur their wrath. All I am saying is that there was a time when they were fetching water from the same source where other animals were also drinking from. So, if he wants me to put it that way humbly, I want to leave it here.

Mr Speaker, I was just saying that the hospital was abandoned, and the maternity and children's wards were

unusable. Somewhere in 2021/2022, it took the President, who was then in the opposition, with his wife, Mrs Lordina Mahama, to go and build a maternity and children's wards, temporarily for temporary purposes.

Mr Speaker, I remember very well in 2017 when I asked a Question about Bole town roads and Bole hospital. I was asked what John Mahama was doing when he was the President and why we could not fix our problems, and that I was now coming to ask them questions when we had wasted our chance. God being so wonderful, he has brought back H.E. John Dramani Mahama. All the projects that they abandoned; I want to assure them that all of them will be constructed. But for their information, the Minister for Health is on his way to Bole to take possession of land for the construction of the Bole District Hospital.

My good Friend Hon Alexander Akwasi Acquah was the Deputy Minister for Health, yet he could not lobby for his hospital to be renovated. And I thought he would have hidden himself because if he brings it up this way, he is simply telling his people that even though he was a Deputy Minister, he failed to lobby for his own hospital to be renovated. He is asking John Mahama not to build the Bole District Hospital. Rather, he should go and renovate his hospital. I think that, for me, it is not the way to go.

Having said this, let me now go to my substantive issues. Mr Speaker, I intend to look at paragraphs 465 to 466, which are on the Land Commission. And also look at paragraphs 466 to 470, which are



on the Forestry Commission. Finally, look at the Minerals Commission and the fight against *galamsey* and paragraphs 471 to 474.

Mr Speaker, I will start with the Lands Commission. If we go to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Minister for Finance stated that he is going to allow the Lands Commission to retain all its Internally Generated Funds (IGF). The reason is that we intend to digitalise the land administrative system. This has been an albatross around the necks of several governments. They could not solve the problem. John Dramani Mahama and the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources are providing a solution. The solution is to think outside the box. There is no money. It is estimated that we will need about US\$160 million to fix the problem.

What the Minister and the President intend to do is to allow the Lands Commission to retain its IGF 100 per cent, and that can be a source of payment to any individual or company who wants to partner with the Lands Commission to be able to resolve this problem. This is what we call governance. This is what we call *nyansa*.

Mr Speaker, if we were able to do this—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Yusif, withdraw the word *nyansa*.

**Alhaji Y. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, I withdraw, but this is what we call wisdom. When the Lands Commission is able to digitalise its system, we are going

to benefit immensely. One, our revenue mobilisation will go up. Two, it will reduce corruption. Three, those of us who have businesses and go to banks looking for money and are asked to bring collateral, and they do not have land documents, even though they have the land.

Once we digitalise, and land registration becomes faster, one can register their land and use it as collateral to be able to take loans from the banks. And when one takes the loans, there are multiple effects. When one takes the loans, one is able to invest the loans into their business; they will be able to grow their businesses. They are going to employ people and pay taxes as and when profits are declared. This is what John Dramani Mahama seeks to do.

Mr Speaker, let me now move on to the Forestry Commission. The Forestry Commission is on record as having started the implementation of one of our manifesto promises. That is the Tree for Life programme. The Tree for Life programme is targeted to plant about 13 million seedlings. We have, so far, distributed about 17 million seedlings, and we are ensuring that these seedlings germinate. We are not going to just plant them and leave them there, as it happened under the previous administration. We are going to invent and put in place a technology that can monitor these plants as and when they are planted. And that is the difference.

Mr Speaker, there is also a very important point that I need to mention. Even though I will still go to the fight

against *galamsey*, it is important to put on record what we inherited. With about 228 forest reserves, we inherited 44 of them, which had been affected severely by *galamsey* activities. And out of the 44, nine were totally gone, under their watch.

There is a relationship between forests and water bodies. The water bodies take their source from the forest reserves. If a forest reserve is polluted, like the way they polluted them, the water that runs from the forest ends up in the water bodies. That was what they left for us.

Mr Speaker, it is refreshing to announce that we have been able to ensure that the 44 forest reserves are now intact. And the 9 that were totally taken over by thugs, we have also repossessed them. We have put our eyes on them, as we speak, and so they are safe.

12:05 p.m.

The Forestry Commission is one of the areas we intend to create jobs. So, the Budget has made provision for that. Next year, we can assure them that we are going to increase the employment of young men and women in that sector.

Let me also talk about an important issue that we should look at. Until a month ago, exporting timber was a problem to the extent that some timber species were rejected. Today, the story is different. We have signed what we call Forest Law Enforcement, Governance and Trade (FLEGT). What it means is that we now monitor and ensure that timber is coming from the right source

and then when it is exported, they will not reject it. This is a milestone, and I think that this House needs to appreciate it.

Mr Speaker, I know there is no time so I will go the almighty fight against *galamsey*, illegal mining. We inherited a very bad situation, and the records are there. If Hon Members want records, they should go and take the performance report of the Audit Service between 2019 and 2024. They should look at that report, and they will weep. Almost all the rules and regulations that we are supposed to follow in the award of small-scale mining licences were not followed. The records are there. Within this period, not a single small-scale company placed what we call a reclamation bond; not a single company. What that means is that when they destroy the environment, they run away and leave it. But if you have a reclamation bond, when you run away, that reclamation bond will be used to reclaim the land. This Administration is going to ensure that the right thing is done. Small-scale mining licences were distributed as if they were rain in a rainy season. People were given these licences even when they did not need it. What we did was to do a review, and out of about 2,178 small-scale licences, I was given the privilege by my hard-working Minister to review them. When we were done, about 907 irregularities were found. As I speak to the House, we have legally revoked 300 licences, and nobody has been able to challenge us.

Mr Speaker, we are not ending it there. We are now reviewing large-scale licences, and it is refreshing to announce

once again that we have seen a situation where one concession is sold to two or three people. The records are there, and that is what we inherited. There was once a president who said to us that when it comes to the fight against *galamsey*, he was putting his presidency on the line. What happened? He failed woefully in the fight against *galamsey*. It was during his regime that they withdrew the intervention of the military. In 2022, the military was withdrawn, and that is why everybody then can go into the forest reserves and water bodies to do mining. This is their records. Let me also put on record that—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up. I will proceed to give the floor to Rev John Ntim Fordjour. You have the Floor.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member hold on.

Before you come in, permit me to acknowledge the presence of Christ Fellowship M. A. Junior High School, led by Eunice Obeng, a teacher. They are from Bortianor-Ngleshie Amanfro. We also have Prestigious Heritage International School, led by Mr Samuel Appiah, administrator. They are from Kpone-Katamanso.

Then we have Pentecost University, led by Kobi Confidence Amenyo, student leader. They are from Anyaa Sowutuom. They are numbered 101, 96 and then 69 respectively.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, on your behalf, I welcome

them. May you have a fruitful stay in Parliament.

*[Pupils of Christ Fellowship M. A. JHS were acknowledged]*

*[Pupils of Prestigious Heritage International School were acknowledged]*

*[Students from Pentecost University were acknowledged]*

Mr John Ntim Fordjour you now have the floor.

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Financial Policy of the Government that was presented by the Minister for Finance. At the outset, I comment that at a time when the security of this country is fast deteriorating; at a time when insecurity is on the rise; at a time when insecurity in Bawku, sadly, is increasing the death tolls of our brothers and sisters; at a time when Sampa is in turmoil and insecurity is killing our brothers and sisters in Sampa; at a time when in President Mahama's own backyard, rather regrettably and sadly, insecurity is displacing 48,000 residents, killing several hundreds of them, and further displacing 23,000 as refugees, 10,000 as refugees in Burkina Faso, and 13,000 as refugees seeking refuge in Ivory Coast; at a time when *galamsey* has become a sophisticated national security threat and a criminal cartel; at a time when citizens no longer feel safe in this country; at a time when citizens fear for their lives, and the situation is deteriorating to a point that even security

officers fear for their lives, men in uniform are running helter-skelter for their lives, as we see in videos; at a time that not a single man passes without this country waking up to the sad news of killings of our security officers, one would have expected, Ghana expected, all of us expected, that sensitively and prudently, the resources of the state would be applied, aligned to the priorities of our national security strategy.

But to the disappointment of Ghanaians, we rather saw procurements, a Budget of procurement related to the security sector, all aligned to luxury jets, all aligned to transportation aircrafts, with complete disregard to the sensitive times that we live in. This House has never opposed retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces. This House has never opposed the modernisation of the fleet of the Ghana Armed Forces. This House, particularly on the Side of the NPP Members of Parliament as history tells us by *Hansard* from 2017 till now, has always led the charge and advocated for the retooling of our security agencies. A time has come when our Colleagues in the NDC want to blow several billions of cedis— 3.6 billion cedis in the Budget. The same NDC who as recent as 2024, opposed every attempt by former President Akufo-Addo to retool the Ghana Armed Forces and to have conversations around a befitting aircraft to carry our soldiers and the President. They indicated that there is a Falcon, a Falcon that in their words was in pristine condition and one of the best in Africa. Ghana woke up a year later only to in addition to the so-called aircraft in

pristine condition, spend GHC3.6 billion on luxury aircraft, two luxury jets; all for the luxury and transportation of the President and the Executive. This is on page 202 of the Budget. Could one not have been enough? Could we not have been sensitive to the Ghanaians and our soldiers and prioritised the real needs that they have? When you speak to the soldiers, what they tell you is that Ghana Armed Forces is a fighting force, therefore, their priority is the battle readiness of our soldiers.

12:15 p.m.

But the NDC Government, President Mahama and the Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, who doubles as the Acting Minister for Defence have rather chosen to turn the Ghana Armed Forces from a fighting force into a luxury transportation agency. That is rather sad.

In this House, as a matter of record, in line with national security strategy priorities, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government brought to the House, the acquisition of six fighter jets. Colleagues on the Majority Side, stood in this Chamber to oppose it. It is same for my good Friend and current Chairman of the Committee on Defence and Interior, Mr James Agalga. He was the only one who said that the House should not politicise it. He will speak shortly after me and corroborate this point. The rest torpedoed those efforts.

When the soldiers requested for Offshore Patrol Vessels (OPVs) to safeguard the territorial integrity of our waters and our maritime security, the

NDC Members of Parliament opposed it. Today, all of a sudden, they have found priority in buying four helicopters and two luxury jets. In addition to the two OPVs, they opposed just less than a year ago. They can oppose OPVs and bring it back. We would support them.

They can oppose an aircraft that can safely carry the President, the Vice President and the Executive and bring it back and we will support them. However, it should be modest. Just one would have been all right. We wanted to prioritise the safety of the President, but they opposed it and have crossed the lines into luxury for the President. That is insensitivity and hypocrisy on the highest level.

Mr Speaker, but one thing that is sadly missing is that, of all the things they opposed, they now, “*nicodemously*”, want the whole of Ghana to use their taxpayers’ money to support. They thought about their luxury and forgot about the soldiers. The six fighter jets are missing from the pages of this Budget. There is not a single allocation for acquisition of fighter jets.

Now, any aircraft can potentially get into our airspace and the might expected of our Air Force to confront such unauthorised flights might have been jettisoned. So that, the President and the party who opposed and politicised presidential jets, can have three presidential jets that is the Falcon and two additional fighter jets. Is that not insensitivity? Is that not complete disregard to the suffering of the ordinary Ghanaian? They opposed one and you want three.

Mr Speaker, that said, at a time when this country was expecting that the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ghana Police Service would be resourced to be able to deal with a pressing security challenge, *galamsey*, that has now moved from polluting our water bodies and destroying our forests, to poisoning our staple foods such as our favourite *kontomire*, cassava for making *fufu*, *mankeni* for making *ampesi*. At a time when unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) was what our security agencies requested for, so that they can fly these mighty aircrafts over unauthorised water bodies and forests where mining is taking place and bastardising our environment.

With that, perhaps, without the intent to kill but they can shoot to scare perpetrators of illegal mining poisoning our waters, they said “no” to UAVs and “yes” to three private jets for the President to fly in. At a time when the same security officers they deployed to safeguard the water bodies in this country, they have turned around and embolden foot-soldiers to openly and brazenly attack them. This is the time we should have thought about reducing the interface of human intervention, even to possibly prevent possible compromises as may be the temptation. But they said no to UAVs and yes, to three private jets.

Mr Speaker, I insist that when the Estimates are brought to this House, we as a Parliament exercising oversight with the responsibility of the security of our country in our hands, will insist priority alignments. We will insist that two of the helicopters must be dropped for fighter jets. We will insist that one of the luxury

presidential jets must be dropped for UAVs, so that we can save our country.

Mr Speaker, on 23<sup>rd</sup> June, 2025, on the front page of the Ghanaian Times, you would find the picture of President Mahama and the heads of our security agencies, the IGP, the Director General of the Ghana Prison Service, the Chief Fire Officer and the Comptroller General of Immigration, making a big announcement of GH¢1 billion to retool the security sector. They took the smiles and took pictures for the front page. Even today, when you check the website of the Presidency, the big announcement is there. From June till now, where is the GH¢1 billion for the retooling of the Ghana Police Service? It is “419”. Where is the GH¢1 billion to retool the Ghana Fire Service—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Rev Ntim Fordjour withdraw the term, “419”

**Rev Fordjour:** I am guided, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please withdraw.

**Rev Fordjour:** I withdraw the term ‘419’. Mr Speaker, I take guidance and I withdraw.

Where is the GH¢1 billion they promised the Ghana Police Service? They have deceived them. They have failed and turned their backs on them. Where is the GH¢1 billion they said they would use to retool the Ghana Immigration Service so that they safeguard our borders in the face of

threats of violent extremism and terrorism? They promised to resource the Ghana Immigration Service with GH¢1 billion, so that they would tighten our securities and increase the resilience against terrorists. They turned their backs on them and they are making announcements.

When you look into the Budget, page 202, under the Ministry of the Interior, Mr Speaker, apart from the salaries of our police officers, immigration officers and prison officers, there is no CAPEX. There is no substantial innovative CAPEX; the situation is so sad. When you visit the Kotoka International Airport, Tamale Airport, sea and land ports like the Tema Harbour and Takoradi Harbour, when you visit this major entry and exit points, the only intrusive narcotic detection scanner you would find is at the Aviance Cargo Section. It is only one. We do not have an intrusive narcotics detection scanner. So, in these sophisticated technologies, where perpetrators can conceal cocaine, cannabis and all manner of illicit drugs, contrary to the rhetorics and the promise of President Mahama to fight these matters, the ports are open. The only scanners we have is the usual security scanners, not narcotics scanners.

We called the Minister for the Interior before this House and he made a pledge before this very House that he will prioritise the purchase and installation of intrusive narcotics detection scanners. In the Budget, there is no indication of those. Is it an indication that those matters we have been raising, which they were denying,

is it an indication that green light must be given for all to do what they want? Let us tighten the borders and ensure we invest into the fight against narcotics.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Prison Service has introduced strong innovations in the areas of industry, agriculture, and health. We were expecting that there would be allocation in the Budget to be able to retool them in obtaining agricultural and industrial equipment.

So, the Ghana Education Service (GES) can outsource the sewing of some of the uniforms of our children to the Ghana Prisons Service even as a way of Internally Generated Funds (IGF). There is no indication of that.

12:25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as I conclude, the goods and services already have an inadequate allocation in here. We are pleading that the trajectory of releases should not be like we saw in the year under review. There should be adequate releases commensurate with the needs. Let us not starve our security agencies. Let us invest and prioritise our security agencies because for Ghana, it is all we have and it is—*[Interruption]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon James Agalga, 15 minutes.

**Mr James Agalga (NDC — Builsa North):** Mr Speaker, thank you.

My Ranking Member, Rev John Ntim Fordjour, the former Minister for

Defence, Mr Dominic Nitiwul, and Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, the MP for Damongo, in contributing to this debate, appeared to be singing from the same hymn sheet.

Mr Speaker, there are a lot of inaccuracies that I would want to clear before I proceed to raise my substantive points. First of all, Reverend Ntim Fordjour says there is rising insecurity in this country. But he failed to furnish this House with statistics.

Mr Speaker, previously, when the New Patriotic Party (NPP) was in power and I had the opportunity to debate their Budget Statement, I furnished this House with statistics, crime statistics, and struck comparisons between how the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in 2016-2012 fared and how the NPP fared starting from 2017 all the way to the time they left government. I furnished this House with statistics but he did not. All he said was that there is rising insecurity in Bawku, Sampa and elsewhere but the Bawku conflict did not start today. In fact, the Bawku conflict escalated under the watch of former President Akufo-Addo before he left office.

Mr Speaker, because tensions are very high in Bawku, I would not want to say certain things. I will not say certain things because as members of the Committee on Defence and Interior, we are required to be very careful when we make statements because we are privy to information that not everybody is supposed to be privy to. But all I can say is that the Bawku conflict escalated

under the watch of former President Akufo-Addo. At the moment, we are trying to manage the Bawku conflict in a manner that will result in lasting peace to the people of Bawku.

Mr Speaker, when I listened to Rev Ntim Fordjour, he says they tried to retool the security services and the NDC Members of Parliament opposed them. How did we oppose them? In 2024, former President Akufo-Addo, in his Message on the State of the Nation, indicated that they were going to retool the security services and we all applauded him. But when the time for action came, they failed miserably. I would give you an example, former President Akufo-Addo ordered that we procure six fighter jets for the Air Force. This House supported the deal, check the *Hansard*. We supported the deal. But where are the jets? How did the deal end?

Mr Speaker, that deal did not go through because of the reckless management of this country's economy by former President Akufo-Addo and his cousin, Mr Ken Ofori Atta, who led this country into a debt re-structuring scenario. And because we are undergoing debt restructuring, the facility we took from the Czech Republic did not work and we never received the jets.

Whose fault is it that the jets never came? My Ranking Member is now asking us to tell him where the fighter jets find expression in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy. We should be asking him to tell us where the jets are. We should be asking him. When

he spoke about the offshore patrol vessels — an agreement — a loan transaction was brought before this House just before the Eighth Parliament dissolved. But as Members of Parliament, we are required to do due diligence. So, without our prompting, even the one who brought the transaction before this August House, the Hon Minister for Defence, was willing to withdraw the same loan agreement and that was exactly what happened.

Mr Speaker, today, if we have brought back the same transaction, budgeted for it, to procure two offshore patrol vessels so that we can properly manage our exclusive economic zone, protect our oil resources which are embedded in the belly of the ocean, I think the least my Ranking Member can do is to lend us support. Not to refer us to the situation whereby they attempted to rush this House into passing a loan agreement which was worth over €200 million. Did they not want us to do due diligence? I think one of the principal objectives of every Member of Parliament is to do due diligence and save this country money when financial transactions are brought before us. And that is what we shall do even with respect to this particular—

Mr Speaker, like I said before, so far, my Hon Colleagues have all spoken from the same hymn sheet. The impression has been created that rather than retool the security services, the NDC government is intent on buying luxury jets and this is a fallacy. The Air Force, and my Ranking Member knows that they have their critical requirements and needs. In fact, the Air Force ought to beef



up its strategic lift capabilities. In doing so, it is not just about a presidential jet. It is about acquiring transport jets that can be used for medical evacuation, to transport our troops to peacekeeping operations.

Mr Speaker, as a country, is it not a disgrace that whenever we are sending our troops to peace operation theatres, we would have to hire private airlines such as Emirates and Egypt Air, to transport our them to peace operations theatres? That is how serious the situation is. So, when you find in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy the Minister for Finance's submission that we shall acquire two aircrafts, one for medium transport functions and the other for long-range transport operations—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members standing should resume their seats. Hon Kabiru, you cannot turn your back to the Mace. Hon Agalga, you have the floor.

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, so when we find an expression in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy made by the Minister for Finance to the effect that we shall procure one medium-range transport aircraft and another long-range jet, it does not mean we are buying luxurious jets for the President. In any case, why are they even running away from the issue of the acquisition of presidential jets, assuming without admitting that one of the jets is a presidential jet? Why? Did President Kufuor not procure the Dassault Falcon 300? When President Kufuor acquired it, did he ever sit in that jet as President for

one day? I ask you the question. Did he ever sit in it for a single day? He did not.

Mr Speaker, the first time this country acquired a transport jet for transporting VVIPs was in 1962 by president, Dr Kwame Nkrumah. This country used it until 1976, when Kutu Acheampong, then Head of State, came to the realisation that the aircraft President Nkrumah had bought had outlived its usefulness. So, Fokker 28 Fellowship was procured for this country for VVIP transportation.

12:35 p.m.

After Fokker 28, in 1998, the Gulfstream GIII was bought by President Rawlings, and if we read the *Hansard*, it was this Side of the House, the NPP Members of Parliament, who stood in opposition against the acquisition of the Gulfstream. In fact, former President Kufuor refused to have anything to do with the Gulfstream. That was how the Falcon Dassault was acquired, and so today, if we are saying that we would acquire two transport aircraft for the Ghana Air Force, it is because it is a requirement of the Air Force itself, and the Hon Ranking Member knows this.

Mr Speaker, please, they should go back and look at the critical requirements of the Air Force. The four helicopters that we shall acquire constitute a critical requirement of the Ghana Air Force, and so, I just want to inform my Colleagues that when it comes to retooling of our security services, they are the ones who have failed this country. Starting from the time when former President Akufo-

Addo assumed the reins of Government in this country, I want to ask them; how many aircraft he procured for the Ghana Air Force? Not even one.

My Hon Colleague also spoke about the Hon Minister for the Interior. He says he has gone through the Budget, and that he has not seen anything in terms of the capital expenditure (CAPEX) for the Minister of the Interior. Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, Rev Ntim Fordjour has not read the Budget Statement and Economic Policy well. I would appeal to him to take pains to read the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and if he does so, he will find that on page 166, under the Ministry of the Interior, allocation has been made in terms of CAPEX for the acquisition of 100 firefighting tenders.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Mr James Agalga, I will pause your time.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin** — *rose* —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, just to be fair to Rev Ntim Fordjour, I know my Colleague, Hon Agalga, is a great debater. If that aspect of that submission can be taken out—We know he is defending the acquisition of the presidential jet. He can defend it, and that is all right. But to say that Rev Ntim Fordjour has not read the Budget, I mean, that is quite unfair. So, Mr Speaker, if he can withdraw that.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr James Agalga?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, on the point made by the Rev Ntim Fordjour, he indicated in his submissions that there is no CAPEX for the Ministry of the Interior, and I am saying that if he reads this Budget well, he will find out that under CAPEX, GH¢1.5 billion has been allocated for the acquisition of firefighting equipment.

Mr Speaker, you would find that on page 166.

*[Uproar]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please, proceed.

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, President Mahama, ever since he was sworn into office in January 2007, has been flying in commercial flights. He has never used the money of the taxpayers to rent private jets which have the capacity to afford him the opportunity to bathe mid-air. He has not done that. Mr Speaker, we look at the duration for the manufacture of the jets that we intend to buy, we would realise that it will take us four years to build same. What that means is that President Mahama thinks about the future of this country, not his own luxury. If it were about luxury, Mr Speaker, President Mahama would have opted to rent because renting private jets is immediate. One gets to experience luxury immediately, but he has taken a decision which is futuristic. The time period for the manufacture of the aircraft that we are going to purchase will take us four years. So, please, do not mislead the public by creating the impression that the

motivating factor for the acquisition of the aircraft, which would give all of us a strategic lift capacity, is because the President wants luxury for himself. That argument cannot fly.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by stating that under the NPP administration, in fact, promises were made and never fulfilled. This House was called upon at some point to approve of a loan for the acquisition of 12 Armoured Personnel Carriers (APCs). I was one of the people who led the charge because I am very passionate about security related issues. We approved of the loan of US\$80 million for the acquisition of 12 APCs. Mr Speaker, in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Minister for Finance made it clear that we paid US\$40 million, and yet not even one single APC was delivered to this country.

Mr Speaker, it takes an efficient Hon Minister like Dr Ato Forson to renegotiate the agreement in order that Ghana would have value for money. But for the intervention of Dr Ato Forson, we would lose everything and not get even a single APC. That is the extent to which the Government failed to retool the security.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up.

I now give the floor to Mr Akwasi Konadu, you have 15 minutes.

**Mr Akwasi Konadu (NPP — Manhyia North):** Mr Speaker, thank

you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement numbered 7(a) on the *Order Paper* for today.

Mr Speaker, I will start by letting us understand what the Budget means. It is an expression of the aspiration of a country broken down into financial terms for economic development. Such aspirations, must carry integrity.

Mr Speaker, I will proceed to show you today that this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy does not carry integrity. It does not seek to do what it proposed to do. The theme for this Budget Statement and Economic Policy is “Resetting for Growth, Job and Economic Transformation”, and the same was the theme for the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, “Resetting the Economy for the Ghana we want”, and on it, it said “the Big Push”. I never knew that they were carrying themselves to push us into a manner to reset, which means to erase all the gains that we have made. No wonder this Budget seeks to erase the gains that we are making and we have made in the years gone by.

But, Mr Speaker, let me say this, and I am grounded on the authority of the Bible, and I quote from John 4:38, which says,

“I sent you out to go and reap what you have not laboured for; what others have laboured for...”

Mr Speaker, our Brothers on the other Side and the Government are reaping the labours of His Excellency

Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. Why do I say so? When the figures are good, they claim that in eight months they have done it, but when accountability rests on their doorsteps, they ask us how we are using eight months to judge them?

Mr Speaker, they cannot approbate and reprobate. They cannot lie prostrate and still want hair on the back of their head.

Mr Speaker, let me show you how this Budget Statement and Economic Policy lacks credibility, but I must say, statistics were called for, and the Global Peace Index, as of September 2025, showed us with a trend analysis that in 2021, Ghana was the second peaceful in Africa, and seventh now in Africa, 38<sup>th</sup> in 2021, and now 67 in Africa.

Mr Speaker, my Brother Sulemana is sitting in my seat. Just about nine months ago, I was on that seat. He made claims about the digitalisation of the land records. I personally, in September 2024, was in Lands Office in Takoradi. I witnessed the digitalisation of land records in this country; the same as in Koforidua. We on the other Side will not be like them; we will not be like our brothers on the Other Side.

Mr Speaker, my Brother talked about Forest Law Enforcement, Government and Trade (FLEGT) license. It was in this Chamber that I led, under the supervision of my Hon Minister, Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, that we brought the Report from the Committee of Lands and Forestry.

With the Forest Law Enforcement, Governance and Trade (FLEGT) license to be laid on this Floor, Members of this House marched and said they will not allow us to meet. We lost the opportunity of becoming the first in the world to issue FLEGT license. We supported them just about two months ago. I led the support, and we passed the FLEGT license here. Now they are basking in that glory. No worries. It is good that they are basking in that glory.

12:45 p.m.

Mr Speaker, under the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources in this Budget—under the watch of the then Majority from 2021 to 2024, we launched a number of flagship programmes: the Green Ghana Initiative, Community Mining Initiative and National Alternative Employment Livelihood Programme (NAELP). Mr Speaker, the Green Ghana Initiative was oversubscribed. It yielded positive results for this country to the extent that we earned US\$4.862 million in 2023 in terms of carbon credit trade. Mr Speaker, same as REDD+, which gained this country US\$16.9 million.

Mr Speaker, what did we see after that? All that we saw, is in this Budget. They claim that they have transformed Green Ghana into what is termed as Tree for Life. It is undersubscribed and they are not worried about it. People do not have the confidence in it. Out of 30 million targeted seedlings that they wanted to plant, only 17 million has been planted.

Mr Speaker, under the mining sector, in March, 2025, the Hon Minister disbanded all forms of community mining schemes. On 2<sup>nd</sup> May, 2024, under the leadership of the former Minister, I was in Hemang Ankobia to inaugurate a community mining scheme. He told us it was only in terms of names. Mr Speaker, the renaming and number of outdoorings that have happened in terms of projects that were being ran under our tenure—I think that the unfortunate incident of 6<sup>th</sup> August would let us stop some of these things and continue on the path when we see righteousness being done in this country rather than continuously renaming them.

Mr Speaker, why must we change the name of community mining into something that we call Cooperate Mining Scheme? Of what benefit would that be to us? Mr Speaker, another lack of integrity that I see—let me ground myself again in this. The Bible again says in Mark 16:15 — let it not be said that what I am about to say is not found in the Manifesto of the NDC, neither was it said by the President or the Vice President. The Bible says in Mark 16:15, and Christ instructed: “Go ye into the world and preach the gospel to all creation.”. President Mahama in 2024 commissioned his party members to go into the country and say it as it is. Now H. E. President Mahama is the President. In October 2024, Mr Speaker, on TV3, the Majority Leader now said that why must they deploy military to chase our young men and women? It is not good. Mr Speaker, he talked about the Galamstop Taskforce. All that he meant

was that there should be a cessation to all forms of small-scale mining activities.

On 9<sup>th</sup> October, the Deputy General Secretary of the NDC said, “*Adwuma no ye be ma mo akoso aye, se mo to aba no ma yen.*” To wit, we will continuously do the job if you vote for us. Again, on 8<sup>th</sup> November, 2024, Hon Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa, now the Minister for Foreign Affairs, said to us to ban all forms of small-scale activities, now, completely and immediately. Then a question was posed to him on Metro TV by the host, on whether he meant all forms, not only in forest reserves? He said yes, all forms of small-scale mining activities. That was his answer.

On 9<sup>th</sup> September, in a one-on-one interview with the current Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Mr Emmanuel Armah Kofi Buah, he said we had to declare a state of emergency and go back to the drawing board. Mr Speaker, the drawing board is a table with a sheet. I do not think they even have a drawing board. My venerable former Majority Leader, is not here so I do not want to mention him, he said there should be a cessation.

Mr Speaker, why do I say so? All of these things are not found in the manifesto and were not said by the President, but it was a commission. Matthew 16:18 says that “... and on this rock, I will build my church.”. When Jesus commissioned his apostles, it was upon Peter he built his church and that is why the seat of the Pope is called the seat of Saint Peter. Now it is upon them that H. E. Mahama has built his Government.

Hon Ablakwa is the Minister for Foreign Affairs, Hon Buah is the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and Hon Haruna Iddrisu is the Minister for Education. Mr Speaker, they form the core of government.

Mr Speaker, why can we not say what they said they were going to do, which is to put a total ban on small scale mining activities? They are not willing to do it. All of these things were said when we were told that nine forest reserves were under siege but now there are 44. These 44 are being said to be declared national security zones, which requires that we deploy military persons permanently in these areas. If indeed the policies that are being implemented by this Government would yield a result, it would call for a reduction in the number of allocations that will be made in the operations of anti-*Galamsey* activities. It tells us that there is no way that we are committed to fighting small-scale illegal mining activity in this country. Do we know why? It is because it is the—*[Inaudible]*—upon which this country's economy is being driven now. We are being told that four million people are engaged in it and that if we ban it, we are not going to get the forex reserve that will help us run this economy. Indeed, it is true. The activities will not yield the results.

Let us go into the Budget. On Page 163, the allocation for this year alone for National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS) is GH¢150.3 million. In 2027, it is projected that GH¢177 million will be used. In 2028, it is projected again in page 193 that

GH¢197.9 million will be used. Mr Speaker, if you have a nephew that you have groomed and trained to pass an exam once and for all, will you make another allocation out of your salary for another re-sit in the same exams in the preceding year? No. I take this very seriously.

Let us pay a glowing tribute to Private Sarfo Agyapong, who fell in the line of duty in the activities of NAIMOS two days ago at Obuasi Airport area. And also, to wish three of his members who are injured, a speedy recovery.

Mr Speaker, this Budget shows no proof of responsiveness. One thing that even baffles my mind, is the duplication of what I see. The allocation for Free Senior High School is GH¢4.2 billion, to end the double track system alone is GH¢1.1 billion. To buy books alone is GH¢3 billion and to build—and what are these buildings going to do? These buildings are to end double track. If that is what it is, there has been a double allocation for it.

Mr Speaker, if we go into the District Assembly Common Fund (DACF) utilisation formula that has been put out, in paragraph 1170 there have been provisions that have been made for kindergarten (KG) blocks to be built and furniture to be bought from that DACF. Mr Speaker, the Budget does not hold hope. In the 24-Hour Economy, the headline that was for the campaign, if the 1-3-3 formula was to be implemented, it ought to reduce poverty, therefore, it would not have called on us to use an amount of GH¢292 million to buy

sanitary pads. Mr Speaker, I like it when we buy it for them. It is important we buy it for our young ladies to go to school. But if they had implemented—it would have helped to reduce that. But the paltry amount of GH¢110 million is being used for that.

Mr Speaker, what I am afraid of is an amount under Paragraph 1171 that calls for GH¢207 million for what they term as “rebasing”. Let me tell the House what they mean by “rebasing” in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Mr Speaker, it says under paragraph 82,

“The October CPI data shows that commodities such garden eggs, cocoyam leaves (Kontomire) or Alefu, Pawpaw, Fresh Tomatoes, Cabbage, Okro, and Fried Fish recorded significant price declines, reflecting the payoff from investments in irrigation, mechanisation ...”

If these things are what they would put in the basket that it is calling for GH¢207 million— They are mentioning *kontomire* in the basket, that is calling for GH¢207 million, I am afraid, is being used to tell us that prices are reducing, at a time when people cannot even pay their electricity bill in this country; when our forests are being degraded and we need to fight these things, yet we are not doing so. Mr Speaker, I am saddened. I am afraid.

12:55 p.m.

Mr Speaker, lastly, we called for decentralisation. We ought to do that. That would help spare industrialisation

in our communities and our localities. But what do we see? Mr Speaker, on the 13<sup>th</sup> November, 2025, the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs issued a letter directed to all Regional Coordinating Councils, telling them that they can only purchase desks from only eight contractors. Mr Speaker, why do they have to cripple the district assemblies? They told them you are giving them all their money, and they put their hands behind them. It is strikingly difficult for me to appreciate.

Mr Speaker, before I sit, when we talk about roads, we have what we term as the food roads. This is under paragraph 981. The World Bank funded 1000 km for GH¢828 million, which means for each road, it is about 838, because it is funded by that. But when we go to the constituency roads, we have 166 constituencies, 10 km of road, with a budget of GH¢3 billion. Mr Speaker, if you divide that, it is about GH¢1.8 million. That is under paragraph 1143 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, why that disparity? This Budget lacks hope. Before I sit down, there is this Kenyan poet, Ngugi wa Thiong’o, who wrote “Weep Not Child”. But I tell my fellow Ghanaians, weep, for this Budget is here to condemn you.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.  
[Hear! Hear!]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I now proceed to give the floor to Mr Ahmed Ibrahim. Mr Vincent Assafuah, can we listen to the other Side in silence?

**Mr Ahmed Ibrahim (NDC — Banda):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Mr Speaker, honestly speaking, Ghanaians would tell you, the case is settled. Ghanaians have come to know, between us and the NPP, who are the best managers of the economy. Mr Speaker, an independent judgment is here with us.

Mr Speaker, I have been here for 17 years. I packed all 17 budgets that have been presented, but the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is the best among all. What we, including 98 Members of my Brothers on the other Side in the Eighth Parliament, were searching for has been found. They themselves passed a vote of no confidence on their own budget by their Minister for Finance in the previous administration. Mr Speaker, not knowing there was somebody among us who could do it.

Mr Speaker, I have been here for 17 years. Ministers for Finance who have occupied that office after their tenure remain in this country. Where is our former Minister for Finance? Where is he? At least, I was here. Where is our former Minister for Finance? I am saying this not as a trivial matter. He occupied the high office of the Minister for Finance. He presented budgets to us.

Mr Speaker, when I came here, the first Minister for Finance was Dr Kwabena Duffour. After his tenure, he remained here. We had Mr Seth Terkper; after his tenure, he remained here. He

was even given an International Monetary Fund (IMF) assignment. He still went and came back. Mr Speaker, I saw Mr Baah Wiredu. After his tenure, he remained here. I saw Mr Osafo Marfo; after his tenure, he remained here. Mr Speaker, where is their former Minister for Finance? That is just one; let us put that aside.

Mr Speaker, on the second point, I hold in my hand the 2011 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Republic of Ghana passed by Dr Kwabena Duffour under the tenure of H.E. Prof Mills and John Dramani Mahama, 'John the Resetter.' Mr Speaker, what we could not do from the year 2000, the NDC did it in 2011, and I hand it over to them. I am talking about the Economic Convergence Criteria of the West African Monetary Zone (WAMZ). Mr Speaker, for the sake of time, I would not quote. My Colleagues should go and find the 2011 Budget Statement and Economic Policy and read page 13. I have so many points that if I dare to quote – time is of the essence.

Mr Speaker, with your permission,

“Madam Speaker, it is significant to note that for the first time, Ghana met three out of the four primary convergence criteria which has eluded us for the past nine years”.

Under the NDC, when we were in government, what Ghana could not do in nine years, we did it in 2011, and handed it over to them.



Mr Speaker, let me take their 2023 Budget Statement and Economic Policy and show their results. At page 16, paragraph 52, with your permission, I quote:

“According to the 2022 Half-Year ECOWAS Multilateral Surveillance report, out of the four (4) primary and two (2) secondary rationalised macro-economic convergence criteria, Ghana met one Primary Criteria, namely the public debt to GDP ratio criterion as shown in Table 3.”

This is by Mr Ken Ofori-Atta.

We are back, let me show you Dr Ato Forson has done. We are the better managers of the economy who are always resetting; —

**Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin)** — *rose*—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, strictly in accordance with the rules, why are you up?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, we have to be fair when we are impugning certain motives, especially when such individuals —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, guide me by the rules first.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, if you may be guided by Orders 122 and 123. Specifically, Order 123; Content of speech. Mr Speaker, we have it as a matter of public record that Mr Ken Ofori-Atta —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please tell me the specific rules that have been breached.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** All right, I would read it out for you. Mr Speaker, I would read Order 123(2) (a) and (b) all through for you since you want to be guided. It states:

“(2) A Member shall not

(a) use offensive, abusive, insulting, blasphemous or unbecoming words on a Member or any other person; or

(b) impute improper motives, or impugn the integrity of a Member or any other person.”

Mr Speaker, let me end there. The Member in his debates, in his submission, seeks to draw Mr Ken Ofori-Atta, the former Minister for Finance, into his submission. Mr Speaker, this is the analogy he makes when he says that all past Ministers for Finance have remained in their country, but Mr Ken Ofori-Atta has left the jurisdiction —

1:05 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, this does not offend the rules that you have quoted.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, can I finish? You have asked me, let me finish.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** It does not offend the rules.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I am submitting.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** If that is the reason for which you are up, I am sorry. Hon Minority Leader, take it easy, and kindly resume your seat so that I can give the floor to the Hon Member to continue the debate. With all due respect, Hon Minority Leader, today I have decided to go by the rules.

Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Ahmed Ibrahim, you have the floor.

**Mr Ahmed Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, I was asking rhetorical questions, but I needed to solicit an answer from the Hon Minority Leader, who knows very well that I respect him—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please proceed. You are eating into your time.

**Mr A. Ibrahim:** He gave us authoritative information that by 18<sup>th</sup> February, the Hon former Minister for Finance was going to be in Ghana. So, I am asking, where is the former Minister for Finance? And I thought he was going to tell us his whereabouts.

Mr Speaker, let me come to what the former Minister for Finance could not do to the extent that 88 of our Colleagues on the Minority Side were calling for his removal by going to the Flagstaff House, by casting a vote of no confidence on him, and this was led by the distinguished Hon Davis Ansah Opoku, and we supported them.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin — rose —**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Ahmed Ibrahim, hold it. They will stop your time for you.

Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, my Colleague says that I made a promise to bring Hon Kenneth Ofori-Atta in February, and that he is asking me where the man is.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, again, we want to go strictly by the rules as I have announced right from the beginning. Go straight and tell me the rules that have been breached.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Order 123, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Which specific rules of Order 123?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, 123(2) (a) and (b) read together.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, tell me what he said that has offended Order 123(2) (a) and (b).

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, it is his argument that I had made a promise in this House that I was bringing Mr Ken Ofori-Atta in February, and that he is asking me because I said that. Mr Speaker, I have not said that.

Mr Speaker, with respect, the former Minister for Finance was out of jurisdiction, and an enquiry was made,

and right at the Despatch box, I produced a letter from his lawyers to the effect that he was seeking medical treatment outside the country. [*Uproar*] Again, there was a second letter from him to the Office of the Special Prosecutor (OSP). That was the matter between him and the OSP, where he again indicated in a letter from his doctors that he was receiving medical treatment and was undergoing surgery, and that his stay in the United States has been extended to ensure full recovery.

Mr Speaker, it would be unfair, therefore, for Hon Ahmed Ibrahim to attempt to say that the man has refused to come to Ghana. These are medical issues, and it is a matter of public record. My Colleagues would have to be very fair to Mr Ken Ofori-Atta. Any of us can go through that situation. He made available to all of us in this country his medical record. He published them; his lawyers attached his medical record and the letter from his doctors, and made it available to the public. It is not a secret, and they know. So let us be fair; it can be anyone tomorrow.

So, Mr Speaker, let us not use our debate to impugn improper motive. There is a public record that states clearly why Mr Ken Ofori-Atta is not in Ghana. Let us be fair. His time will come.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let me use this opportunity to admonish the entire House that debates can be interrupted under Order 122 based strictly on certain conditions, and the conditions are clearly spelled out. On hindsight, let me read Order 122(5). If

you get up on a point of order or point of procedure, what exactly is expected of you? Order 122(5) says:

“A Member who interrupts debate on a point of procedure or order shall state the rule of procedure the Member on the floor has breached or the procedural matter that requires a ruling of the Speaker before subjecting the Member on the floor to the ruling of the Speaker.”

We need to comply strictly with these rules. Interruption of debate does not give room to any Member of Parliament to argue. You would be completely out of order if you use Order 122 to engage in rebuttal. You can take note of the points when it gets to your turn, then you can state so. So, we should stop acting out of order.

Hon Ahmed Ibrahim—

**Mr Ayariga** — *rose* —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader, why are you up?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I rise on a point of information.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Majority Leader, what is the point of information?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, the Hon Member indicated that the—[*Uproar*]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let us look at Order 122(c), it says, “Debate may be interrupted by a

point of information, elucidation or clarification". So, if a Member gets up to say, I am rising on a point of information, I would ask the Member, what the point of information is.

1:15 p.m.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, Mr Ahmed said that the former Minister for Finance left this country claiming he was going for medical treatment, and it became an issue in this House. The Minority Leader, Osahen Afenyo-Markin, came to this House to assure us that on a given date, in July this year, the former Minister for Finance will be in Ghana and he will produce him.

Mr Speaker, I was the one who rose on a point of order that day and objected, and asked him not to undertake to do something that he would not be able to deliver on. He did not listen to me and persisted. So, it is indeed true that he came to this House and promised to produce Ken Ofori-Atta, and has not done that.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Majority Leader, so your point of information is that what the Minority Leader said he did not say, as indicated by Mr Ahmed, he said it. *[Laughter]*

Yes, Minority Leader, you have the floor.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, the records would bear me out that indeed, when the respected former Minister for Finance had an issue with the Office of the Special Prosecutor

(OSP), which matter the Majority Leader himself came to apologise for— He came and used this Despatch box to apologise on behalf of the Government for the mishandling of the whole matter. We, as Leaders, owe a responsibility and duty in the matter.

I, right here, indicated that Mr Ken Ofori-Atta had written to the OSP through his lawyers that he was going to be in the country on or before May, not July. This was in February. Mr Speaker, in the letter, Mr Ken Ofori-Atta again indicated that he had been booked for surgery. When the time came and his doctors further advised that the surgery would require some healing process, he again wrote, this time not only a letter from his lawyers, but a letter from his doctors. They wrote and indicated that they had booked him for surgery and that the post-recovery would take some time.

Mr Speaker, this is a matter of record. I, again, made this known right here in this Chamber. So, it is not a matter of resigning or making a promise and failing to honour that. Let us put things in the proper context. All I want Mr Ahmed Ibrahim to understand is that when it comes to ill health, all of us may go through it one way or the other. If a man is going through a serious medical condition, how many of us would be bold enough to disclose our medical records? But the man has disclosed his medical record.

Mr Speaker, that hospital where he is receiving treatment is a renowned medical hospital in the United States. Let us be fair to Ken Ofori-Atta. It can be

you tomorrow. This is not the way to treat a fellow citizen.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, can we proceed with the commentary? It appears we are deviating from the issue at hand.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, then talk to the Majority Leader. It is the Majority Leader.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Can we proceed with the commentary on the Budget?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, this is very important. No, no, no. When Mr Speaker gave indications, he kept talking and said things that he should not have said. He gave the impression that Members on this Side are insensitive to the medical condition of Mr Ken Ofori-Atta. That is the impression he has sought to give.

Mr Speaker, Mr Ken Ofori-Atta was very sick in this country; we could even see it on his face. But at that time, it was sweet to be a Minister for Finance. In spite of his ill health, he persisted and insisted on remaining in this country as Minister for Finance. How come, suddenly, because today he is being sought after by the law enforcement agencies, he cannot live in this country and is claiming illness? He was sick when he was the Minister for Finance. We all saw it. He was sick.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, can we make progress? I strictly want to give the floor to Mr

Ahmed Ibrahim. Hon Ahmed Ibrahim, you have the floor.

Hon Members, let us shift away from the medical conditions of the former Minister for Finance. Please continue with the commentary on the debate.

**Mr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, I already laid the foundation that the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is the best in my 17 years' stay in this House. There is no controversy about this. I am saying this as a Senior Member of this House.

Mr Speaker, the first point was on ECOWAS convergence criteria decisions. I will go to page 9 of the 2026 Budget. In 2011, we handed over the economy to our brothers on the other Side, and they took us back. The best managers of the economy are back, and we are doing wonders again. Look at the results. Paragraph 45, page 9, and with your permission, I will read:

“Mr Speaker, by the third quarter of 2025, Ghana had met five out of the six ECOWAS convergence criteria, a marked improvement from the same period in 2024. This progress reflects the Government's strong commitment to macroeconomic stability, supported by frontloaded fiscal consolidation, credible structural reforms, and an appropriately tight monetary policy stance.”

Mr Speaker, in Table 5, the Budget Deficit, including Grants, is less than or up to 3 per cent. We have achieved 2.3 per cent. Inflation (annual average) is

less than or equal to 5 per cent. That is the only one that was not achieved. Central Bank Budget Deficit, zero financing, have been achieved. Gross External Reserve of at least three months, Mr Speaker, we have achieved 4.8 per cent. Nominal Exchange Rate, plus or equal to 10 per cent, we have achieved it. Then Public Debt to GDP ratio, not more than 70 per cent, we have achieved 48.9 per cent.

So, if we achieved five out of six, which they could not do, between them and us, who are the best managers of this economy? The case is settled. Never compare yourself with the NDC on the economic front again. We are the best managers of the economy. The records are showing.

Mr Speaker, let me go to a statement made by the former President of this country, President Nana Akufo-Addo. He was crying about rating agencies and was saying that Fitch Solutions, Standard and Poor (S&P), and Moody's Corporation were biased towards Africa because they downgraded his economy and was, therefore, calling on the African Union to design its own marketing scheme.

1:25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, externalities are externalities. They are the independent rating agencies rating NDC and NPP. They have rated both of us. What you could not do, we have done it. Mr Speaker, with your permission, I read:

“Ghana's President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo has lashed out on international credit rating agencies across the globe, describing its rating as reckless. According to President Akufo-Addo, the consistent downgrade of Ghana's economy by credit rating agencies have contributed to the country's current economic woes. ‘Reckless downgrade are not in the best interest of developing countries like Ghana, he cried.’”

We give you an economy and after that they are being marked and they are crying because they have failed. They were crying in the hands of rating agencies. NDC has come. Mr Speaker, he cried and said we should fund our own African rating agencies. We should ignore Moody's Corporation, ignore S&P and ignore Fitch Solutions. We have not changed any of the examiners. The same examiners, and the same marking scheme. This is what you could not do.

Mr Speaker, we gave them an economy rated B-, in 2016, they took us into an economy rated junk. We are back; we are not assessing ourselves.

Mr Speaker, let me take you to the 2026 Budget and Economic Policy.

I am older than all of them sitting there in this House, so when I am talking, they must listen, including the Minority Leader, all of them, before you came, I was here. I have no co-equal there.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, be mindful of your time.

**Mr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, by experience, they should learn from me. I cannot conclude without bringing our results to the House. Mr Speaker, S&P has graded Ghana; Fitch Solutions has graded Ghana; and Moody's Corporation has graded Ghana. What they could not do; we have done it. All these have found space in the Budget. If in all the 16 West African countries, Ghana is the only country that is leading in terms of meeting the economic convergence criteria; if in the whole West African Monetary Zone, and S&P, Fitch Solutions and Moody's Corporation are all saying the NDC are the better managers of the economy, what is their case? They should bring their marking scheme. They should bring their results. They cannot see their Minister for Finance to bring them their results. Their examination papers are with him.

By now, former Minister for Finance should be going from Joy FM and TV3, defending the previous case. Where are they? This was what Mr Seth Terkper did and we are here. *Mo be ka ho*.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, what is the meaning of that?

**Mr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, you know they are good at being in opposition. They will stay there for long. You can see how the Minority Leader is enjoying his Minority Leadership. What he said was hell, is he now enjoying it? When we were here, he said come to the Minority— He said he will not sit on that

chair. Today he is taking that luxurious chair and even decorating it. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, on a very serious note, the third point, in 2024, the entire DACF that the previous administration gave toward Local Government in this country was GH¢347 million. They could not pay the 2024 allocation. They collapsed District Assemblies; moneys were not sent to them. From 2021 to 2024, the entire amount that they transmitted to District Assemblies was GH¢7.2 billion. In the first quarter alone, the Ato Forson–Mahama Administration sent close to GH¢987 million. In second quarter, GH¢1.8 billion, third quarter, GH¢1.4 billion. By the fourth quarter, Mr Speaker, we have equalled all their four years' disbursements that they have done to the Local Government. Do they believe in district assembly's Local Government Administration?

They themselves, in 2023, came to this House and told us that they are going to assess all the district assemblies by performing District Assembly Performance Tool (DPAT) 8. By 2024, they could not do it. They could not even assess the District Assemblies in 2024, so DPAT 8, they could not do it. In this 2025, Mahama Administration performed the DPAT 9. The DPAT 8 is cancelled because they could not do it.

We have done the DPAT 9. About 118 District Assemblies have passed and 143 have failed. That is the 2024 assessment. All the 118 that have passed, each is getting about GH¢9 million, GH¢8 million, and GH¢10 million, to

be added to the District Assemblies Common Fund.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up.

Hon Members, clearly, any time there is interruption, I will ask the timekeepers to stop your time for you.

I will then proceed to give the floor to Mr Ansah Opoku. *[Interruption]*

No, I have given the floor to Mr Opoku.

Thank you, Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku, you have the floor.

**Mr Davis Ansah Opoku (NPP — Mpraeso):** Mr Speaker, if we were to look at the behaviour of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, clearly, it sums up this whole Budget. The Budget is empty. They say that empty barrels make the most noise.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, you are speaking for 15 minutes.

**Mr D. A. Opoku:** Everything that the Minister for Local Government has sought to do in this House is to just make empty noises by not even making any reference to this Budget.

**Mr Ibrahim — rose —**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Mr Ansah Opoku, you could have proceeded to make your point without making reference to the conduct of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. So, please withdraw the aspect that you are making reference to the conduct of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

**Mr D. A. Opoku:** Mr Speaker, before I withdraw, when the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs was making his submissions, he pointed to the fact that I, a then first-timer, a Backbencher, led a whole *coup d'etat* to take out the Minister for Finance. This is factually inaccurate, but you allowed this to go on. You never asked him to withdraw. I stood up, Mr Speaker, you saw me and decided that you were not going to call me. And I am surprised that you are asking me by stating a fact that a Minister has stood here for 15 minutes, made no reference to this Budget—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is not what I am asking you to withdraw. You are saying that by the conduct of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, it shows that the Budget is empty. Will you consider that as an insult?

**Mr D. A. Opoku:** No, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** You are saying that his conduct is empty. That is what I am asking you to withdraw.



**Mr D. A. Opoku:** Mr Speaker, I am going to point to the fact that this Budget that has been presented by Dr Cassiel Ato Forson is indeed empty.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why I am asking you, you can describe the Budget without referencing it to the conduct of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

**Mr D. A. Opoku:** Mr Speaker, I am guided. If you so believe that I should withdraw, I have withdrawn. I think that I need to move on.

Clearly, making noise to explain something that has nothing, does not solve problems. When the Minister presented the Budget, in fact, he termed it 'Resetting for Growth, Jobs, and Economic Transformation.' In my small village in Mpraeso, people were full of excitement. Indeed, Mr Speaker, I remember that very day. I even got angry with my Side that we were delaying the process and that we should allow the Minister for Finance to present that sweet news that he wanted to give to Ghanaians. It turned out, that whatever the Minister did here, he was just engaging in sloganeering. The Budget was heavy on slogans, but empty on substance. That was what I made reference to, that if you come here and present an empty Budget, all your people can do is to now seem to want to make noise and shout.

1:35 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Budget or economic management is premised on trust. In fact,

if a person really wants to lead people, one needs to build trust. The people must have a certain level of trust in that person. Mr Cassiel Ato Forson came to this House, presented the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy and made some claims that, Government intends to invest some moneys into goods and services and capital expenditure.

At the end of the day, in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, we all found out in this House that, only 56 per cent of goods and services was released. It is not surprising that today, you walk through some Ministries in this country and their lifts are not working, "common" pens, A4 sheets are not there for people to work with. That is what they were making a lot of noise about how global rating bodies as Fitch and other are rating us and so on.

Mr Speaker, my little boy is 10 years old. Recently, I found out that the young boy comes home and he seems to be growing lean. But every day when this boy is going to school, daddy gives this boy money. Then, we tried to find out from him, by asking Johnny why he is growing lean even when daddy gives him money. We concluded that, Johnny now saves the money in the bank without feeding on the money. When Ghanaians give them money to spend on the economy and they decide that they are going to keep the money in their pocket and spend, their accounts would look big. But in actual sense, their economy will be growing lean and that is what has happened to the economy of this country under H. E. John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, another interesting point is on their investment on capital expenditure. Only 34 per cent was released during in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, that is alarming. Because this is a government that came in with big promises as the Big Push Agenda, MahamaCares and others. They said that roads are going to be constructed in this country under the Big Push Agenda.

At the end of the day, the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* and every project under this Government only saw 34 per cent in capital expenditure. What it means is that, they are not even paying contractors. They are releasing moneys to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture to buy more *nkokɔ* so that 50 households would get money. What it means is that, even common desilting of gutters is not being done because. They are not releasing the money to do that; it is problematic. How can we have an economy that is growing in name, but in actual sense, the economy is growing lean because the Minister for Finance has refused to release moneys for all of that.

Mr Speaker, the Minister also said that, ever since they took office, they have awarded close to about GH¢63 billion worth of contracts under the Big Push. But we all know that in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, what the Minister announced was some GH¢13 billion. In this Budget, what the Minister has announced is GH¢30 billion. If you were to add 13 plus 30 billion, we are looking at GH¢43 billion.

Is the Minister telling us that now the Government is engaging some financial engineering to want to find some moneys from elsewhere when this Parliament has not approved that extra GH¢20 billion? We want to find out from them. Where are they getting that GH¢20 billion from to fund the Big Push Agenda? Is it a case that they are making noise, telling the people of Ofoase, that they are going to construct a bridge when indeed, the money for that wonderful edifice that they showed us is non-existent?

Mr Speaker, I think it is important that in the spirit of promoting the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 and ensuring that this Government does not violate it, we investigate where this Government is going to get the GH¢20 billion extra to fund their Big Push Agenda. It is a matter of concern.

Mr Speaker, there has been unrealistic revenue that this Government announced. Indeed, there has been some shortfalls. In the 2025 revenue targets, they have made some GH¢7.7 billion in total revenue and GH¢6.8 billion in domestic revenue. I was surprised when I heard Dr Ato Forson claiming in this House that, his Government is projecting some 18.8 per cent increase in 2026, without any credible measures. It is worrying and I think that they ought to check.

Mr Speaker, it is not surprising that today if one goes to the Okaishie or Makola Market, a lot of the business communities have lost confidence in this Government. *[Interruption]* Indeed, in the trading markets, clearly, if 25 out of

the 45 treasury auctions fail, which represents some 55 per cent of failure rate happens in this country, there is a big problem and I think that they ought to watch it.

Mr Speaker, I want to zoom into the communications and the digitalisation industry. Indeed, this is a sector that should anchor Ghana's future. Communication is everything. People are talking digital. We are looking at how artificial intelligence (AI) is able to transform this economy. Indeed, only GH¢331 million was allocated to the Ministry of Communication. This is quite worrying. We never saw any AI readiness plan in this Budget. There was no national digital architecture announced in this Budget. No broadband affordability strategy was announced in this Budget. No structured digital transformation roadmap was announced in this Budget.

Mr Speaker, the only thing that we saw and the only news that we heard, was that Government is allocating some GH¢70 million for Digital Youth Hub. But this Digital Youth Hub, as a Member of the Committee on Information and Communications, not even a single plan has been laid before us. We do not know what this Digital Youth Hub is going to do, whether it is will create jobs or train people and so on. I say this because in the last Budget, the Government said they are investing GH¢100 million in their One Million Coders Programme.

This year, they are making claims that they are also investing the same GH¢100 million in the One Million Coders Programme. But as a Member of

the Committee on Information and Communications, I have sat through this Committee for nine months. Not even one single coder has been trained. So, one wonders where this money went. Where did this money go to? Indeed, they mentioned big moneys in this Budget, but virtually do nothing.

Mr Speaker, another interesting bit is rural telephony. We know that under His Excellency Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, over 1,200 rural telephony sites were planted across this country. This Government intends to invest some GH¢30 million in the rural telephony project. But what is lacking is that, we have not seen any constituency list or map. We have not been told whether this particular year, we want to do this number or amount of rural telephony projects across the nation. They have virtually done nothing, which is a bit worrying. They have talked about their Coders Programme and all of that.

Mr Speaker, to end, I want to bring this to the attention of this House. When the NPP Government, under H. E. President John Agyekum Kufuor, wanted to have something to do with Ghana Telecom, they came to this very House. In fact, Ghana Telecom found expression in the Budget, the very year that the Government intended to do something about it.

Mr Speaker, today, as we speak, there is a company called AT. AT Ghana is a merger between Airtel and Tigo. AT Ghana is struggling. As a Member of Parliament, I would be there, then the Government through the Ministry would

announce that they are looking for international partners to come and take over AT Ghana. In the next breath, the Minister will go to AT Ghana and assure the people that 300 jobs will be maintained. In another breath, it would be announced that the Government is considering a merger between AT Ghana and Telecel.

Mr Speaker, this is the House of Parliament; we represent the over 30 million Ghanaians. If this matter is not brought before us, then who else should get to know what is happening in this AT Ghana merger? I thought that if indeed this Government wanted to protect over 300 employees at AT Ghana and the over 4 million subscribers at AT Ghana, AT Ghana should have found expression in this Budget, but they did not. All we care about at the Ministry is how we are able to get a promotion for DSTV.

1:45 p.m.

Today, that is the focus of the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations. All they care about is how Ghanaians are able to subscribe to DSTV to get more offers. We have now virtually turned the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations to a promotional centre for DSTV. When the focus should be on how we are developing or expanding infrastructure in this country, the focus should be on how we are planting more telephony in rural areas, and how we are helping young girls learn ICT.

Mr Speaker, I can conclude that this Government, when it comes to AI, digitalisation, and how we are able to digitise everything that we do in this country, has lost focus. They have failed and that is why, to the young boy who is sitting in Kwame Nkrumah Circle, hoping that this Government would inject some money into his programme or app that he is developing, I am telling you that this Government is a “*medɔfo adaada me*” Government that we need not put trust in. To the young boy in Mpraeso, who is hoping that this Government is going to employ him, the young boy in Zabzugu, who is hoping that this Government is going to provide some employment to him, what I would say is that they should look no further because *aban wei deɛ ɔmɔnyɔ*. In fact, it is wrong and they have no plans for us.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, you know, we speak English. Whatever you say in Twi, you must translate it into English.

**Mr D. A. Opoku:** *ɔmɔnyɔ* is a Fante word. If a Fante man says, *ɔmɔnyɔ*, my big Brother, Hon Samuel Atta-Mills is here, it means that something has gone bad — *asei*, *aporɔ* and that is what this Government has done.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Samuel Atta-Mills?

**Mr Samuel Atta-Mills:** Mr Speaker, what he said is not Fante and it does not sound like Fante language. The real

fancy word is *omo nyoo*. What he said is wrong. So, he needs to withdraw.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members — Hon Ansah Opoku, you do not have the floor.

**Mr Ansah Opoku:** Mr Speaker, I seek to withdraw *ɔmɔnyɔ* and replace it with *omo nyoo*. [Laughter].

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** It is now the turn of Hon Eric Opoku. You have 15 minutes.

**Mr Eric Opoku:** Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion on the floor of the House. My Colleague, Hon Davis Ansah Opoku, MP for Mpraeso, has described the Budget Statement and Economic Policy before the House as empty and the basis of this statement is that the Budget Statement and Economic Policy did not provide enough resources for capital investment. I want to start my debate from these critical issues that my Colleague has raised before the House.

Mr Speaker, I agree with him. Capital expenditure or capital investment induces long-term economic development. It creates sustainable employment. It increases incomes and establishes conditions that encourage private sector investments. So, when we invest in capital projects, we are creating jobs and we are expanding the economy. As the economy burgeons, people are liberated from the shackles of poverty in the country.

Mr Speaker, I have with me the 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy

presented on the floor of this House by our Colleagues when they were in the Majority. In 2024, just 11 months ago, the Budget provided for capital expenditure which was GHC28 billion and they indicated that out of the GHC28 billion, the Ghanaian economy can generate only GHC18 billion. The remaining GHC10 million was to be borrowed from outside Ghana. It is just 10 months ago. Today, we are debating the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy and the allocation for capital expenditure is GHC57 billion.

Mr Speaker, it is indicated in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that out of the GHC57 billion earmarked for capital expenditure, this economy can generate GHC45 billion. In fact, when we look at the total capital expenditure in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy and look at the capital expenditure plus the capital component of the earmarked funds and in the 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, altogether, their total was GHC38 billion. Today, after just 10 months in office, the Government of the NDC, under the visionary leadership of H.E John Dramani Mahama, has increased our capital budget from the GHC38 billion to GHC77 billion. That is 103 per cent increase and they condemn this and describe this document as empty. It means they do not have a better appreciation of it.

Mr Speaker, it is important to note that in the 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they projected that if they happen to be in government again, in 2026, they will increase Ghana's

capital budget to GH¢44 billion. We are doing GH¢77 billion and they have the courage and temerity to stand before this august House to describe this Budget Statement and Economic Policy as empty.

Mr Speaker, he also spoke about non-payment of contractors. I have the 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy here, the Budget their administration presented to this House just 10 months ago. It was projected that in 2026, if they happened to be in government again, they would pay arrears of GH¢12 billion. Read the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. We have provided arrears of GH¢29 billion. *[Hear! Hear!]* My Hon Brother, you do not know the contents of the Budget.

Mr Speaker, I am quoting from page 161 of the 2026 Budget and page 176 of the 2024 Budget. I see a shift from expenditure on goods and services to expenditure on capital projects. We now have a government that thinks about the people, that thinks about the future of this country and the government says that let us not spend the moneys in the offices. Let us prioritise the interests of the Ghanaian people above our private interests.

Mr Speaker, I want to demonstrate this. In the 2024 Budget that they presented before the House 10 months ago, they stated under goods and services that in 2026, they will spend GH¢14.5 billion, that is GH¢15 billion on goods and services. That is office expenditure. Government changed and the NDC Government is in office and we have presented the 2026 Budget. We are

saying that no, we cannot spend GH¢15 billion as office expenditure. We have reduced it to GH¢13 billion and we are not applauding this. They even projected that if they happen to be in government in 2027, office expenditure will increase to GH¢17 billion. We, in the 2026 Budget, are saying that we would do GH¢14 billion. We are cutting down office expenditure and increasing capital expenditure. Is this not a way to grow the economy? So, what are they criticising?

1:55 p.m.

Mr Speaker, on a more serious note, they were on a journey to destroy our nation. I would demonstrate that. I am happy that at the Gallery today, we have school children and they will listen to what they have done; the damage they have done to the Ghanaian economy, yet they still have the guts to stand before us here to debate us.

Mr Speaker, in 2024, this is the Budget they presented before us here.

*[Hon Member raised the 2024 Budget]*

*[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, in the 2024 Budget, they told us that inflows into the Health Insurance Fund will be GH¢9 billion, and that Ghanaians will pay for quality health services amounting to GH¢9 billion. And when they get that GH¢9 billion, they will make available only GH¢6.5 billion to the Fund, and they will spend the rest on office expenditure. So, quality health care was never their priority.

Today, they sit here and argue that we lack basic things in our hospitals. Today, in the 2026 Budget, we have projected an inflow of GH¢11 billion into the Health Insurance Fund, and we are saying that the entire GH¢11 billion will be released to the Fund. Is this not good news? *[Hear! Hear!]*

Now, on Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), the reason we still have schools under trees in this country or the reasons our children are still being schooled in dilapidated blocks, is because they collected moneys meant for the development of school infrastructure and diverted it for other purposes.

Mr Speaker, in their 2024 Budget, they indicated that inflows into GETFund will be GH¢8 billion. When they received the GH¢8 billion, as Ghanaians pay taxes for them to build schools, to develop education, and deliver quality education, they gave Ghanaians, out of the GH¢8 billion, only GH¢3.2 billion. My Brother, Mr Kwaku Kwateng, is here. He knows this, but he cannot talk about it. This is what he did. So, Ghanaians pay taxes and they ask the Government to take our taxes and build schools for our children. The Government took the money, GH¢8 billion, and gave just GH¢3.2 billion to GETFund to build schools. Even with that, they collateralised GH¢60.2 of the GH¢3.2 billion through a vehicle called Daakye PLC. They think we have forgotten? Today, in this Budget, NDC is saying that for GETFund, we are expecting an inflow of GH¢10 billion, and we would give the entire GH¢10 billion to GETFund, to enable them to

build schools, and they call this Budget empty. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, on paragraphs 557 and 558 of the Budget, we are saying that because of the resources we are making available for the development of education, in 2026, we are building two technical universities; one in Jasikan and the other in Techiman. We are saying that we are also partnering with the Catholic church to build a new university in Damongo. And you think that the people are not happy? We are saying that we are building two public universities.

Mr Speaker, are they saying that the people are not happy? Within one year, we want to build five universities. They should tell us whether, in their period of eight years, they were able to complete two universities in this country? And now, they call this empty.

Mr Speaker, let us move on to the Road Fund. I have heard some of our Colleagues complaining that our roads are bad, so we should fix the roads, and they amounting pressure here and there, as if they do not know what they did. In their own 2024 Budget, they projected revenue inflow of GH¢2.8 billion into the Road Fund, and said that when they receive the money, they will give the Road Fund only GH¢1.1 billion. Today, we are projecting GH¢3 billion into the Road Fund, and we are saying that we are giving the entire GH¢3 billion to the Road Fund for the maintenance of our roads.

Mr Speaker, President Mahama, through this Budget, is laying a solid

foundation for the development of our country. [*Hear! Hear!*]

For the first time in the history of this country, President Mahama is proposing in this Budget to construct an expressway in Ghana. We have never seen that in Ghana. Apart from Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah, who constructed the motorway, President Mahama is the next President to construct an expressway in Ghana. That road spans from Accra to Kumasi. According to the design, on that road, we are constructing has eight interchanges. And they call this Budget empty?

Mr Speaker, apart from Dr Kwame Nkrumah, who invested in the construction of the Akosombo Dam to generate 1,200 megawatts of power? That huge investment is still benefiting Ghanaians. President Mahama is the next President, and in this Budget, he is proposing to set up thermal plants to generate 1,200 megawatts of power. And they say this is not a good Budget?

Mr Speaker, I think it is important for us that after the presentation of the Budget and during the post-Budget workshop, they allow us, the Ministers who generated the Budget, to come, participate and educate our Colleagues, especially those in opposition, because I have listened to all the arguments they are talking about. They are just debating on commentaries. They are not talking about substance.

Mr Speaker, let me crave your indulgence —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let me also announce the presence of students from the University Basic School, North Campus. They are led by their headmaster, Mr Victor Fiifi Addison. They are from Cape Coast North and are 144 in number.

We also have Weija Model Basic School. They are led by their headteacher, Ms Dorothy Phoebe Mbroh. They are from Weija Gbawe, and are 104 in number.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them and urge them to have a fruitful visit to Parliament. You may resume your seats.

*[Pupils of Weija Model Basic School and University Basic School, North Campus were acknowledged]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, it is now the turn of Alhaji Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana. You are speaking for 15 minutes. You have the floor.

2:05 p.m.

**Mr Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana (NPP — Gushegu):** Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to contribute to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy before this House.

Mr Speaker, before I go to the substantive issues, I would like to quickly take note of a comment regarding the intention to produce up to 1,200 megawatts of power. Mr Speaker, what we are seeing today happened in



2015. In the heat of the *dumsor* crisis, what the NDC Government did to us as Ghanaians was to go about signing more power purchase agreements. In the end, what happened? We had over-subscribed. Mr Speaker, we have 5,300 megawatts of installed capacity, and peak demand is about 3,500 megawatts. We have in excess of almost 2,000 megawatts. So, what are they signing 1,200 megawatts for? Mr Speaker, we must be very careful because when they do this, they add to the charges that the Ghanaian people have to pay. It is the reason we were paying nearly US\$600 million annually. In 2018 alone, we paid extra capacity of US\$1 billion.

Mr Speaker, what are we generating the power for? The production or transmission side? What we need more is the distribution side; how to take power to the distinguished Leaders' communities in Bawku Central and to Hon Doyoe's community. The power is available. We need the transmission lines and we need to distribute the power. Basically, that is what we need, not to go and add to power which we already have.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member just before me should have looked at the Public Gallery today and compared the Public Gallery to Thursday when the Minister for Finance was presenting the budgets. Today's Gallery is even more full than what we saw on Thursday. It tells us the level of lack of confidence in the investor community. The diplomatic community was not here. The only person that we found was the chairman of the NDC. Apart from him, nobody

was interested. It was as if they knew that the Budget Statement and Economic Policy was going to be as empty as the Public Gallery.

Mr Speaker, I refer to page 76 to 77 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the area that has to do with transportation. I have read the Budget and appendices and it is extremely sad that this Government is paying so much lip service to the railway sector. I see only GHC70 million being allocated to the railway sector. We have to put our money where our mouth is, is that not it? Mr Speaker, GHC70 million comes to about less than US\$7 million. What can US\$7 million do for the railway sector?

Mr Speaker, I will give the House one example. The construction of the 97-kilometre standard gauge railway line from Tema to Mpakadan cost us almost US\$500 million. So, if they throw US\$7 million at the railway sector, what are they doing? Mr Speaker, US\$1 billion has been raised in this Chamber and we know what US\$1 billion can do. From where we ended at Mpakadan, we would need about US\$1 billion dollars to take the railway line all the way to Nkwanta.

Mr Speaker, there is a very good reason we have to do this railway. Our government ended it at Mpakadan. What they have to do in order not to make it a stranded asset is to do the exit terminal at Mpakadan and the entry terminal at Buipe so that we can move cargo on the barges all the way to Buipe, then move them to the northern part of the country and to the Sahelian regions.

Mr Speaker, what are we seeing? As we speak today, the Adum to Kaase railway network lines contract has been cancelled by this Government. With this same US\$1 billion that I am talking about, we can construct a railway line from Accra and go 250 kilometres past Kumasi, but all we are thinking about is presidential jets for the luxury of the Executive. Is that their priority? Is that what they told the Ghanaian people? The people are suffering and they are buying jets. To do what?

We have natural resources at a place called Sheini in the Zabzugu - Tatale area. We have petroleum deposits and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and its subsidiary ExplorCo have started activities in my constituency. Mr Speaker, we need to do these railways so that when we find the products and mine them, we would be able to move them to areas where we can ship them to where they are needed.

Mr Speaker, so what are we doing? It is a litany of misplaced priorities. We are doing an expressway *na aye deen*? Mr Speaker, we have an existing road to Kumasi which we have dualised from Accra to Apedwa. What is left is for us to be able to dualise the rest or make it three lanes. Mr Speaker, why are we doing an alternative road? So that what? We maintain the two? They are going to be maintaining the expressway and the current road. This is misplaced priority and I want to submit, with all due respect, that the Minister for Finance and this Government and Cabinet must reconsider that decision; it is misplaced.

They can do roads in their various communities. Do they not need them?

Mr Speaker, you can see that my Colleagues on the other Side are not here because they are going to chase roads, but this Government is going to put the road in one area. We have a challenge. H. E. the President, in July this year met with the Ghana Institute of Freight Forwarders and they put some concerns before him. Mr Speaker, if you will permit me, I will read just a portion and I will lay it at the Table. The President of the Ghana Institute of Freight Forwarders said, and I quote, "If you have 20 containers on one bill of lading, you are charged 20 separate administrative fees. But in China, you are charged only once per bill of lading.". The President directed that they something should be done about it.

Mr Speaker, we compare with what is happening in Nigeria. When we take the typical custom clearance documents in Nigeria, there are 13 charges: import documentation fee, port additional charge, container cleaning and maintenance, tellers release, amendment charge, stamp duty, documentation fee issuance, container deposit, another container deposit, and the last one. They are 13. Mr Speaker, in Togo, they have eight. Mr Speaker, I need help to mention the number of charges that we have when we take our custom declaration form. Import levy, import Value Added Tax, import National Health Insurance Levy—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Can you also do us a favour by telling us the effective dates?

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** Which one?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The effective date of what you are reading.

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, this is the rate. We were told by this Government that they were going to do something about the port charges. I am going to demonstrate that nothing has been done.

Mr Speaker, effective today, it is Import levy - 1, Value Added Tax (VAT) on imports - 2, National Health Insurance Levy (NHIL) on imports - 3, GETFund Levy - 4, Import Excise duty - 5, examination fee - 6, AU levy - 7, ECOWAS levy - 8, processing fee - 9, special import levy - 10, interest charge - 11, state warehousing rent -12, EXIM levy - 13, shippers levy -14, network charge - 15, network VAT - 16, network charge COVID - 17, Ghana Shippers - 18, network charge National Health Insurance Levy -19, withholding tax on imports, and finally, container charges — 21. *Aden?*

2:15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, they were voted into power to come and solve problems, not to leave the problems as they are, and then ask us; when did they come? They are supposed to solve the problem. Mr Speaker, we are told, for instance, that Government officials have gone to COP30 in Brazil. They are attending the

Climate Change Conference, and we are hoping that, at the very least, we will live by what we practice. Mr Speaker, we are attending a Climate Change Conference, and this Government inherited an arrangement that produced 10 electric buses out of 100. As we speak, not a single electric bus has been brought apart from the ones that we gave to this country. Not a single bus.

Mr Speaker, again, when you go to the US\$1 billion, do you know what US\$1 billion can do for Metro Mass Transit Limited (MMTL), State Insurance Company, Ghana Private Road Transport Union (GPRTU), Ghana Road Transport Coordinating Council? It can give them 4,000 buses. All we are thinking about is executive jet; long range, and medium range. Mr Speaker, we have a presidential jet which is operational. It has gone for servicing, and it is currently airworthy. And in the words of the Minister for Foreign Affairs, it is in a pristine condition. We are not opposed to the Government procuring helicopters and other needed accoutrements for the military. But, Mr Speaker, we are opposed to the acquisition of luxury jets for the use of the President and Ministers of State.

Mr Speaker, those are not the priorities of the people. The Minister for Food and Agriculture just left. Currently, in my constituency and in the entire north, some of my Colleagues are farmers—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, you have the Budget before you.

**Mr A.T. Sulemana:** I do have it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Link the Budget to your statement that they are acquiring jets for the Executive.

**Mr A.T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, this one is a matter that has been settled before this House. Mr Speaker, this matter is on page 136, particularly paragraphs 1089, 1090, and 1091—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please, quote them.

**Mr A.T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, on page 136, paragraph 1091, it reads:

“Mr Speaker, the Ghana Air Force will be retooled. Beginning 2026, the Government of Ghana will begin the procurement processes for the acquisition of four modern helicopters, one long-range and one medium-range aircraft.”

Mr Speaker, this is the language that we use when we are buying a presidential jet. Former President Kufuor bought a presidential jet, and this is the language, and when we came before this House in 2022, this is the same language by the Minister for Defence at the time. It is the recommendation of the Ghana Armed Forces that we put before this House. So, Mr Speaker, it is in essence a presidential jet. The current one that we have is in the name of the Air Force, but it is a presidential jet —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, that is your own interpretation.

**Mr A.T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, GH¢200 million has been allocated to the National Food Buffer Stock Company Limited to support farmers. There is a glut. They buy fertiliser for over GH¢400, and sell a bag of maize or soya beans for GH¢200 Ghana. Mr Speaker, if care is not taken, next year, no farmer is going to do anything about this. So, we are sending a word of caution that the GH¢200 million that they have allocated to the National Food Buffer Stock Company Limited to buy products from farmers is inadequate.

Mr Speaker, in the North-East Region alone, GH¢200 million —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up. It is now the turn of Alhaji Bawah Braimah. You have 15 minutes.

**Alhaji Bawah Muhammad Braimah (NDC — Ejura Sekyeredumase):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for permitting me to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy for the year ending 2026. I would like to make a brief comment on the acquisition of aircraft for the military.

Mr Speaker, when the unfortunate incident of the 6<sup>th</sup> August happened in this country, the clarion call was that the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ghana Air Force needed to be retooled. That was the clarion call. Even my Friends on the other Side said it when we met. Their submission was always that President Mahama is looking for a luxury jet. But let me refer them to paragraph 1092, states:

“Mr Speaker, these aircrafts are expected to be delivered in four years’ time, if the procurement processes are completed in 2026.”

So, in four years, in 2030, will President Mahama be the President? No, we are thinking of resourcing the Ghana Air Force to ensure that it will be fit for purpose. As a country, we need to have an Air Force that will be fit for purpose. That is what has found expression in this Budget.

Mr Speaker, let me also thank the Minister for Finance for making provision for the procurement of 100 fire tenders to the Ghana National Fire Service (GNFS). The last time that GNFS was retooled was during President Mills’ time. That was around 2011 when we saw GNFS having new tenders. Now, when disasters occur, or if there is a fire outbreak, GNFS are found wanting to attend to these fires and stop them.

My Brother was talking about the Tema-Mpakadan Railway Line. That project was started under the NDC. The original plan was to take it to Akosombo, and the funding was sought by the NDC. So, they came and completed it; they should give credit where credit is due.

Mr Speaker, let me also state that the future of every country depends on the education of the youth. All of us here, when it is time for school placement, go around looking for good schools for our wards to attend; we look for Category A schools.

Now, the solution to that problem has found expression in this Budget. Currently, 10 Category B schools are going to be upgraded to Category A schools. What do we mean by that? It means that resources are being channeled to libraries, classroom blocks, and IT infrastructure to ensure that at least we have those schools turned into Category A schools. Also, the Government is going to inject money into 30 Category C to ensure that they are also upgraded to Category B schools. This will ensure that when it is time for us to look for placement for our wards, we will not be found wanting.

Mr Speaker, during the previous regime of President Mahama’s Government, he undertook a massive educational improvement in secondary schools by bringing E-Blocks. After we lost power, from 2017 to date, all these E-Blocks have been abandoned at various stages of completion. Now, about 30 E-Blocks will be completed. I am happy and excited because I have an E-Block in my constituency that has been abandoned ever since the NDC lost power, and the people of Ejura Sekyeredumase will be happy to see these E-Blocks brought back to life.

2:25 p.m.

Also, under the same education, Government is constructing about 200 new junior high school blocks. This is an ambitious project to eliminate the schools under trees that we have inherited. Again, 200 new primary school blocks and 200 new kindergarten blocks are also going to be built. All these are coming with furnishings; not empty classrooms as have happened; they will be furnished.

What excites me most is the Teacher “Dabrem” Policy that we propose in our Manifesto. Mr Speaker, every morning in my Constituency, you would find teachers commuting to various places, to villages, to teach. And now that problem is going to be solved by the construction of 400 new teachers’ quarters with four units. It means that each unit can house about four teachers. And this would help in the retention of teachers in the deprived areas and also help to ensure that at least our children, who most of the time are left without teachers due to teacher absenteeism, will be a thing of the past. Also, 2 million mono-desks are going to be constructed to be distributed to schools to ensure that the issue of classroom furniture becomes a thing of the past.

Mr Speaker, I come from an agrarian Constituency, that is, Ejura Sekyeredumase. And what excites me most is the siting of these Farmer Services Centres. When it is time for ploughing or when farming season, you find out that most farmers find it difficult to get tractors to plough their farms. And also, getting credit to buy inputs to use on their farms sometimes becomes difficult. So, with the establishment of these Farmer Services Centres, tractors are going to be made available, fertilisers made available, seed made available, and these will go a long way to help the farmers to be able to produce more and then also to be able to make ends meet.

What also is of importance to me, Mr Speaker, is the 1,000 kilometres of agric-enclave roads. I was in the Constituency last weekend, and the cry of the

constituents was that their farm roads are very bad. This is because previous governments, their government, neglected the roads. Previously, every year, the roads were given on contracts for reshaping. I can say without mincing words that for the past eight years, almost all the roads leading to smaller farming communities in my Constituency were neglected. As such, farmers now find it difficult to even cart their farm produce to the market. So, this programme of constructing 1,000 kilometres roads in agric-enclaves is going to help our farmers to be able to cart their foodstuffs from the farm to the market centres.

Also, we the people of Ejura Sekyeredumase feel that this is a Budget of hope. This is a Budget that is going to inspire growth and also ensure that we get the needed productivity that we want. I would therefore, like want to plead with my Colleagues and all of us here to accept and approve this Budget for the year 2026 and support the Government of Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I will now proceed to give the floor to Hon Martin Kwaku Adjei-Mensah Korsah. Hon Member, you have 15 minutes.

**Mr Martin Kwaku Adjei-Mensah Korsah (NPP — Techiman South):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Government’s Budget Statement and Economic Policy, 2026, as presented to this House.

Mr Speaker, before I go into the subject matter, I just want to say that in engaging in such exercises as we are doing here, trust and credibility is important; consistency is important.

Over the last few days, my Colleagues have sought to point to us a lot of inaccuracies in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. On page 49, paragraph 330, Mr Speaker, I quote:

“Concurrently, the Legislative Review Committee began a review in critical laws, including the Local Governance Act 2016, (Act 923), and the Pre-Tertiary Education Act 2020, (Act 1049), to harmonise our decentralisation framework. These amended laws will be submitted to Parliament in 2026”.

Mr Speaker, I want to submit and place on record that primary legislation for local governance in this country is Act 936. Before Act 936 was (Act 462), the *Hansard* would bear me out. Never have we had any act as Local Governance Act 923. How do you seek to review an act that does not exist? Yet, this is what—[*Interruption*—Please, Mr Speaker, you have to protect me. Yet, this is what the Minister for Finance presented to this House, stated in black and white that Local Governance Act, 2016 (Act 923) for is going to be reviewed. There is no such Act. This adds to the many pointers that my Colleagues have done, that a lot of information in this Budget is inaccurate.

Mr Speaker, going forward it is important—this is the Parliament of Ghana. This is a House of records. The records have captured same, so I would beg of you, Mr Speaker, if you could give directions for this to be expunged from the records, because there is no such Act as Local Governance Act, 2016 (Act 923).

Mr Speaker, again, this country in August 2024, took delivery of equipment under the District Road Improvement Programme (DRIP) to maintain our roads. Every district assembly in this country had a set of equipment. The idea was to make sure that our roads in communities in Ghana are maintained so that we do not yearly spend money under the budget of the Ministry of Roads and Highways to go and reshape and manage roads.

Mr Speaker, it will surprise you to note that having spent US\$178 million to purchase this equipment, this Budget is still allocating money to the Ministry of Roads and Highways for contractors to go and maintain feeder roads. This is wastage. This should never be made to happen. Mr Speaker, DRIP is at a near collapse. When the equipment were delivered, part of the agreement was to have the supplier maintain them. But go round the country today and it is a common sight to see DRIP equipment hang on blocks. I was travelling from Sene to Atebubu, and I found one “caterpillar” hang on blocks. I met the same spectacle in Kumasi a week before. Meanwhile, there were supposed to be mobile service centres. There are reports

of people mismanaging the equipment every now and then.

Mr Speaker, two budgets have been presented in the life of this Government, but nowhere is mention made of the DRIP initiative. We need to take care of our national assets. It will be absolutely unacceptable for Government to spend money under the Ministry of Roads and Highways to maintain our feeder roads when the DRIP equipment is in every community.

2:35 p.m.

They are meant to create jobs. They are job promises that the Government made that it has not been able to fulfil. DRIP comes in handy in providing jobs for our teeming youth. Unfortunately, we are not paying attention to it, and it is being treated in a way that I am afraid may kill this laudable initiative.

Mr Speaker, I want to applaud the erstwhile NPP Government, under Nana Akufo-Addo, for introducing development initiatives such as the Ghana Secondary Cities Support Programme (GSCSP), the Social Cohesion (SOCO) Initiative, the Ghana Productive Safety Nets Project, and so on. These are initiatives that are meant to help accelerate development. Critical infrastructure needs of communities that the Government cannot fund on itself in real time. The Government had to have an agreement with international development partners to support our programmes.

Mr Speaker, I can say it was not until about a month ago that the SOCO

Initiative, which has seen a lot of transformation in Northern Ghana, that communities are benefiting from, is impacting their lives. Unfortunately, it has been on a standstill for about 10 months. Same with Safety Nets. It was not until about three weeks to one month that I was told there was an indication that it was going to happen. I have seen the same expression in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, but it is not right for such a programme to stay idle for 10 months. This Budget does not mention any policy direction in terms of what should be done with the Ghana Secondary City Support Programme. These are laudable initiatives introduced by the previous Government. Let us not kill it under the altar of politics.

Mr Speaker, a lot of promises were made in the 2025 Budget, and the worst has been done in the 2026 Budget. I am sad that the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs has left. If we go to page 86, paragraph 494, we ought to have had before the close of this year, six regional house of chiefs in the six newly created Regions. We ought to have had a royal academy of chiefs and traditional authorities so they could be trained in traditional affairs, as they said at the time. All of these remain empty promises.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Local Government Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, through its agency, the Institute of Local Government Service, introduced a Bill to this House to set up the University of Local Governance and Development, and that got to Second Reading. Because of politics, 11 months



on, the facilities in these centres, Akumadan, Ogbojo and Tamale—Infrastructure projects have been held up awaiting the passage of this Bill so that they can begin to admit students. Today, I am told that the name has changed to Governance and Development University. Same thing, but the politicking has delayed it, and now, we are changing names. We would beg of them to bring the Bill to the House so we can pass it and get to work. Otherwise, Mr Speaker, the delays are not necessary. It adds nothing to it. It does not matter who did what. Once it is going to push in developing the sector in terms of human resource capital, that, for me, is what is important.

Mr Speaker, again, in the last Message on the State of the Nation read by His Excellency the President, John Dramani Mahama, in this House, he mentioned among other things, a water project in Techiman. Mr Speaker, two Budget Statements have been presented to this House after the President's promise, and one of them featured this project. As I speak, the people of Techiman are expectant of the water. Unfortunately, it appears to be missing here. The NPP Government started the project, and so when the President gave the indication that there was going to be a continuation, we were all happy. But it has not happened. I want to use this opportunity to remind the Government that the people of Techiman are waiting for the water project. It is important that we make do with the promise.

Mr Speaker, housing is a problem in this country. The 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy stated that the

housing deficit in our country was around GHC1.8 million. Saglemi has featured in the 2026 Budget. We will be surprised to know that even though the overall project had 5,000 units, we are told in this Budget that under a redesign, the first phase of the project is going to witness 8,000 units to be completed before this year ends. In the original form and shape of the project, they could not complete 5,000. How do they want to now complete 8,000 under a supposed first phase? It is yet another promise made to be broken. It is becoming one too many, and we need to be watchful.

Mr Speaker, today, times have changed. The NDC Government can look us in our faces and tell us that, despite all the economic challenges we have, Ghanaians should continue to wallow in abject poverty. We cannot pay our teachers. We cannot recruit our nurses, and yet, we should buy six aircraft. Nobody, in principle, has any problem with acquiring these aircraft. But they cannot tell me that two presidential aircraft in addition to four helicopters—We cannot be that insensitive to the plight of the poor Ghanaians. The NDC campaigned on the emotions of Ghanaians, that Ghanaians were going to witness a better life. It cannot be, and it should not be on record, that it is in their time, 11 months after coming into office, that they find everything right with purchasing six aircraft. We leave it to the Ghanaian people to judge. It is absolutely not right. This sparks of insensitivity, the Government must reconsider the decision.

*Galamsey* is a major issue. The Government has made efforts, though not encouraging nor impressive. But

what the Government has done so far lends credence to the fact that if the NPP Government had continued with its efforts, we would have made progress. Let me encourage the Government to have every moral high ground to confront the *galamsey* menace, the way it should be. Let it not be said that our compatriots who lost their lives were in vain. The whole country should be behind them because they have every moral authority coming from where we are coming from to confront this menace.

Mr Speaker, it is on record that today the state of *galamsey* is getting worse, and what they prescribed to the then Government is what they are running away from. Why do they want to run away when they have made the situation worse? I think that this Government must have the political will to confront a problem that, somehow, it contributed to deepening while in opposition. Because the then Government had no breathing space in confronting *galamsey*. Today, they are faced with it. They should bite the bullet and ensure that they win the war. I remember— [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up.

I will give the floor to Hon Toobu Lanchene. You are speaking for 15 minutes. You have the floor.

2:45 p.m.

**Supt Rtd Peter Lanchene Toobu (NDC — Wa West):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add to the comments that I have made

since we started looking at the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 fiscal year, themed: Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation. It was ably presented by the Minister for Finance under the authority of His Excellency, the President of the Republic of Ghana. Let me divert a little. My Chairman, Mr James Agalga, and the Ranking Member, Rev John Ntim Fordjour, dealt so much with physical security. I would beg to diverge a little to include technical security as well as human security in looking at the Budget for 2026. It is very clear that my Colleagues on the other Side, any time they find themselves in opposition, they wax lyrically with some brilliant ideas, but when they find themselves in government, it is always a disaster. I cannot believe that you can buy aircraft for the Ghana Police Service and as we sit, we have never seen it fly, yet they have the guts to be talking about aircraft as if they have the knowledge in what to do? That is very serious.

Mr Speaker, in the past, we were all here when they imprisoned the cedi and handed over the keys to the Inspector General of Police. When you imprison somebody in open prison and believing that this image is so rational and has credibility and will not escape the prison walls, you hand over the key to the IGP and gradually the dollar was going to GH¢17.00. I thank the people of Ghana. If they had not kicked these people out, by now, a dollar would have been around GH¢30.00.

Mr Speaker, where are we going as a country? From 1992, we began the journey in the Fourth Republic. In the year 2017, President Nana Akufo-Addo took over this country, and for eight good years, he ran this country, and we do not know what the vision was. The 2026 Budget is anchored on a solid vision, and with your permission let me read paragraph 655.

“Mr Speaker, our vision is simple but powerful: to build a prosperous, fair, and democratic Ghana anchored on freedom, justice, and equal opportunity for all. We seek a nation where every Ghanaian can live with dignity, earn a decent livelihood, and contribute to a future that reflects our shared values and collective ambition — the Ghana we all want.”

Mr Speaker, without a vision, anywhere you decide to go, if you take a step to move forward, you will end up anywhere that is not objectionable. Without security, we cannot have development. Without this vision, there is no way Ghana can be anchored on the resetting agenda. We are building this country based on a vision.

Mr Speaker, a house without security is not a home. Can we imagine that for eight good years, Ghana was anchored on very good slogans? Every Budget that came, came with a beautiful slogan. Let me read one for you. The 2017 Budget, it came with a theme: “Sowing the Seed for Growth and Jobs.” What kind of seed can you sow for eight good years— Even if it were redwood, by now we should have been seeing productive fruits. What kind

of seed have they sown since 2017 that right now when one goes outside, all they see are potholes on our roads and our forests depleted? Everywhere is a disaster. Those are the seeds that they sowed in 2017, and this is what we are harvesting. *[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, they say I should go to the Budget and see if their Budget is not important. I am telling you history. In 2017, it was called the Asempa Budget. I did not know what they gave us. In 2018, they gave us the Adwumapa Budget: Putting Ghana Back on Track to Work Again’. Mr Speaker, you were here with me, 2018 ended, we do not know where Ghana was, yet we were in a disastrous state. In 2024, I am moving from Asempa Budget and I am ending with Nkunim Budget. As if that is not enough, the Nkunim Budget was like bringing the ship that carried the Bible and took away the slaves. The ship that brought the Bible and took away our grandfathers as slaves. They also came with Asempa Budget and ended with Nkunim Budget. Who were the victorious people? Was it Ghana that won? No! It was the NPP, a few of them, who won.

Mr Speaker, moving forward, H. E. Busumuru Kofi Annan, former UN Secretary General, an illustrious son of the soil, in 2004, made a statement that is so telling. He said, we cannot have development without security. This statement stood the test of time. H.E. President John Dramani Mahama is conscious of this fact. That is why he knows that the country cannot develop with a weak security sector. He also knows that one cannot make progress

with rising youth unemployment. It is right in the National Security Strategy document that youth unemployment remains one of the biggest threats to our national development. We all know what poverty can do to a country that is attempting to transform. Poverty is a very dangerous thing and it can actually attract terrorism. When a person is poor, the person is vulnerable. The President is a very gender-sensitive person; he is quite conscious about the power of a woman in economic development. What the woman can do is so telling, that for him, he believes that making a woman a Vice-Presidential candidate, and after becoming the President, for the first time, she becomes Vice-President of this country—This is the first time we are seeing something like that. That is a very gender-sensitive President. This has not happened over our 68-year history as a country.

Mr Speaker, the need for a transformed energy sector— If you are looking at security and you think that energy is not important, if you go to our villages and our towns, in the night, when the streets are lit, it helps security.

But let me take you step by step, retooling the Armed Forces and the security sector. Mr Speaker, we are going to retool the Ghana Armed Forces. If they do not like it, they should take it, because the Armed Forces are our pride. What are we going to do? How can a nation have an Air Force and pilot who has not flown for over six months? What kind of pilot is that? How can you have an Air Force that when there is trouble, there is not even an aircraft to move? We

are retooling the Ghana Armed Forces and we are going to buy four helicopters. Take it. It is good progress. We are going to buy two more aircrafts; one long-range and one medium-range. We are going to buy two offshore patrol vessels for the Navy. If you are conscious of the threat of terrorism from the north coming down south, targeting the coast, you will be very fast in protecting your coastline. The Gulf of Guinea is a very dangerous area as we speak, so we need to empower our Navy to take charge of that zone.

Mr Speaker, if you look at what is happening within the Military circles, — I am talking about human security, we are going to complete the Afari Military Hospital, a 500-bed hospital that was abandoned since we left office in 2016. We have been paying lip service to it. President Mahama is going to complete it. In the Budget, National Anti-Illegal Mining Operation Secretariat (NAIMOS) is getting GH¢150 million to capacitate itself to be able to fight *galamsey*. But NAIMOS is just responsible for the enforcement component of *galamsey*. *Galamsey* is being fought on various angles, and there are several other pillars. The pillar of alternative livelihood is there. The other pillar of responsible cooperative mining and skill development is there, and we are able to put all these things together and let them run concurrently. I am telling you, by the end of 2026, we will begin to see the impact of a very good Budget that does not have slogans. Please, this is not like the Asempa Budget. This is not like the Adwumapa Budget. This is not like the Nkunim Budget. We do not have any biblical quotations in this Budget. We

are walking the talk. We are not quoting the Bible; we are living the word.

Mr Speaker, if you would allow me to talk about employment, let me go to paragraph 1182, and with your permission, I will read:

“Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of government is specifically designed to create up to 800,000 new jobs.”  
[Hear! Hear!]

2:55 p.m.

Maybe if they do not understand, this is 0.8 million jobs that will be created in 2026. So, if the economy and the youth are under pressure and there is so much confusion, it is a security threat. We need to find jobs for our young people and doing so, for our young people, this Budget is created to address that.

Mr Speaker, poverty reduction is very important and I will quote our illustrious son, Mr Kofi Annan again. He says:

“Extreme poverty anywhere is a threat to human security everywhere.”

Mr Speaker, if they are not aware, Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) for the first time, has hit the GH¢1 billion mark. [Hear! Hear!] We are making available GH¢1.1 billion for LEAP. The numbers are increasing; people are benefiting and the pressure related to poverty is going down.

Mr Speaker, being a very gender-sensitive Government, when we talked

about the Women's Development Bank, people thought that we were joking. In the 2025 Budget, when we provided capital for the establishment of the bank, that was just administrative. They said it was not enough, even as seed capital. The Minister for Finance being conscious of the sensitivity of women in our development, has provided GH¢401 million to help in completing the full establishment of the Women's Development Bank. Their sisters and mothers would go to that bank and get some small loans to facilitate their small-scale businesses.

I am excited to talk about the energy sector that connects to security. If we look inside the Budget, on paragraph 898, I read:

“Beginning 2026, Government will commence the construction of a 1,200- megawatt state-owned thermal power plant to offtake the additional 150 million standard cubic feet of gas per day from the OCTP partners and GPP 2.”

Mr Speaker, this plant is twice that of the one which is in Akosombo in terms of generation. Thousand two hundred megawatts is huge but I am saying that if we are able to do this, at the end of the day—My village and constituency have just about 26 per cent of electricity coverage. The gap is huge. So, when I see things like this—We have also GH¢2 billion to support rural edification in 2026. I know that right from Kangba, to Ladette, and to Chiatanga and to many of the communities in Wa West that do not have electricity, they would be excited that this is a Budget of hope.

By the end of 2026, when they come and visit me in Wa West, I will take them around in the night and they would appreciate the power of a very good government.

Mr Speaker, this Budget was presented without Bible quotations. Dr Ato Forson came here without wearing white and was with military guards. He did not come here with police guards. All he came with was just appearing as a very humble and honest person, dedicated to see the transformation of this country. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, Dr Forson has introduced something we call “Forsonomics”. Ato “*ɔforci. ɔreyɛ adeɛ*,” to wit; Ato is doing well. It is very important. When they sit in opposition and watch what the NDC Government is doing—The Ghanaian people are watching all of us and they know that what H. E. President Mahama has started to do for the next eight years, 12 to 16 years, they would be very good in opposition. They should stay there and continue to reduce their numbers. *[Hear! Hear!]* It is not for nothing that the Ghanaian people gave them 38.2 per cent. The 38.2 per cent is supposed to let them know that, what they did in eight years was disgusting.

Mr Speaker, I would like to read—Because they are so interested in biblical quotations, I would like to read a quote to the Bible—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up.

Order! Order!

I will proceed to give the floor to Dr Yaw Isaac Opoku. You have 15 minutes.

**Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (NPP — Offinso South):** Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statements before the House.

Mr Speaker, if you would remember, in the early 1990s, there was a popular musician called Nana Nsiah Piesie. In 1999, he released a very popular song, titled “*Wontumi spelli a mentwere*”, to wit, if you cannot spell, do not write.

Mr Speaker, Ghanaians want the NDC to do an audit and tell them which of the promises they intend to keep and which ones they intend to abandon. If we would remember, in the run-up to the 2024 elections, Dr Eric Opoku, the then Ranking Member on the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs and Mr Cassiel Ato Forson and other leading Members of the NDC, promised to pay cocoa farmers not less than GH¢6,000 per bag.

Mr Speaker, Mr Eric Opoku gathered all cocoa farmers at Dadiesoaba and promised them that when the NDC won power, they will pay cocoa farmers GH¢6,000 per a bag. The promise was so strong that, cocoa farmers believed them. One of the farmers asked the Hon Member, and he responded in Twi saying, “*wogyɛ di s3 promise a woreyɛ yi, mo bɛdi so?*” And the response was that, “*sɛ y’anni so a, na cocoa no ɛyɛ hwan deɛ?*” To wit, if we are not able to keep this promise then who owns the cocoa. Today—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Is that all that you said in Twi? —[Laughter]— Translate everything that you have said in Twi into English.

**Dr I. Y. Opoku:** If we win the 2024 elections, we are going to keep our promise and pay you the GHC 6,000—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But you started by saying, “*wogyɛ di ...*” and others. Translate that too into English.

**Dr I. Y. Opoku:** “Are you sure that when we vote for you, you would keep your promise and pay cocoa farmers GHC6,000 per a bag?” Mr Speaker, a bag of cocoa is selling for less than GHC3,700. *Wontumi spelli a mentwerɛ.*

Colleagues, if you say a prayer, say one for Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. He was the who was able to move the price of cocoa from 475.

3:05 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku, why would you speak Twi and not translate it? What is the meaning of *wo ntumi spelli a*? We speak English on the Floor so when you have the opportunity to speak Twi, kindly translate. I have not heard the translation.

**Dr I. Y. Opoku:** Mr Speaker, to wit, “If you cannot spell, do not write”, *wo ntumi spelli a mɛ ntwerɛ.*

Mr Speaker, if you say a prayer, say one for Former President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. He was the one

who was able to move the farm gate price from GHC475 to GHC3,100.00 per bag.

Mr Speaker, if you would remember, during the 2024 Message on the State of the Nation’s debate, Hon Eric Opoku told this House that the NDC Government invested GHC29 million towards Cocoa Farmers Pension Scheme. I refer you to the *Official Report*, volume 121 edition, 29<sup>th</sup> February 2024, column 39, paragraph 5, with your permission, I read;

“Mr Speaker, on the path to tell the true story to the good people of Ghana, we cannot avoid to add this one. When we were leaving office in 2016, we had set aside GHC29 million to start the Cocoa Farmers Pension Scheme. We left this money in the accounts for COCOBOD. The Government took office and the money cannot be traced”.

Mr Speaker, the NDC has been in office for almost one year now and farmers are asking, can that money be traced now? The GHC29 million, can it be traced? Where was it invested? How much interest has accrued?

Mr Speaker, if it was propaganda, farmers would want to know — *wo ntumi spelli a mɛ ntwerɛ.*

Mr Speaker, our Friends on the other Side have described COCOBOD in several ways. They have said COCOBOD is dying, insolvent, collapsing, wallowing in debts and has overpurchased jute sacks. Today, a

dying, collapsed and insolvent industry, has received US\$2.6 billion in deposits.

Mr Speaker, I refer you to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, paragraph 292.

Mr Speaker, if you would remember, during the reading of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy presentation, when the Hon Minister for Finance got to paragraph 224, you could see the excitement and jubilation on the other Side of the House. They were so happy that the production of cocoa has gone from 530,783 to 603,840 metric tonnes. They were so happy and I was wondering, what the jubilation was about? Have they forgotten that the Minister for Finance was talking largely about the NPP's Administration? They have forgotten that the 2024-2025 cocoa season started from 1st October 2024 and ended on 31st August 2025.

As at January 2025, when COCOBOD was under the supervision of the NPP, cocoa graded, sealed and delivered was 480,519. I take that figure again. As of January 2025, COCOBOD was under the supervision of the NPP, and cocoa graded, sealed and delivered was 480,519.

Mr Speaker, if we take 480,519 from 603,840, the difference is only 123,321. Is that what the jubilation was about? Their season — No, I have told you that the 480,519 was under NPP. Their season starts from 2025-2026. So, all the praises should have been directed to the NPP.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Finance went further to indicate what the reasons accounting for the increase in cocoa production were. I refer again to paragraph 294 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. The increase in production was as a result of the success of the producer Productivity Enhancement Programme (PEP) and I asked myself what the productivity enhancement programmes the Minister for Finance was talking about were. Is it the mass spraying exercise started in 2001 by former President Kufuor? Is it the high-tech or the fertiliser application programme started in 2003 by former President Kufuor? Is it the hand pollination programme started in 2017 by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo? Is it the mass pruning exercise started in 2021 by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo? Is it the mass mistletoe control started in 2020 by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo administration?

Mr Speaker, is it the flower inducement spraying programme started by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo in 2021? Or is it the control of an important pest on cocoa known as *Pseudotheraptus divastans* which was started by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo?

Mr Speaker, if we are talking about records of cocoa production, the highest production ever recorded in this country was under Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. The highest production since records started was under Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. The highest production ever was the 2020-2021 season and the record stood at 1,045,500.



This record has never happened in the annals of cocoa production in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, our Colleagues on the other Side have been talking about a collapsed cocoa industry. If the cocoa industry is going to collapse, it would collapse under the NDC and not the NPP. I would tell you why. I have said this here before, and I would say it again, that the most important factor which is threatening the cocoa industry is cocoa-swollen shoot virus disease.

Mr Speaker, I know *galamsey* is important, I know producer price is important, I know smuggling is important, but the single most important factor is cocoa-swollen shoot virus disease. It will surprise us that between 2013 and 2016, when this country was under the NDC, the control of this dangerous disease was completely abandoned.

3:15 p.m.

Not even one hectare of affected farms was treated between this period. It took the visionary former President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, the bold leader, to introduce pragmatic measures, and when we were handing over in January 2025, 70,000 hectares of CSSVD-affected farms had been rehabilitated.

Mr Speaker, again, if we say a prayer, we should say one for the former President Nana Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. For 33 years, Cocoa Board (COCOBOD) was borrowing from the international market to finance its operations, and the former President

tasked COCOBOD to develop a model that would be self-financing, and in the 2024 and 2025 seasons, no single cedi was borrowed.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, that is the end of your time.

Hon Members, we have done six on each Side.

Leaders, any indication?

**Mr Ricketts-Hagan:** Mr Speaker, as you rightly said, we agreed to do 6 on each Side of the House. So, we are actually done, and we will bring the curtains down with regard to the commentary.

Mr Speaker, I want to make an application about a commemorative Statement that we have here. I believe it was submitted to you earlier, and I want to pray if you will admit it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Chief?

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, if you may indulge me, according to the earlier plan until Mr Speaker intervened, we were scheduled to do nine on each Side, and we had submitted the list as such. Mr Speaker, you came in to give a certain direction. Until then, we had Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah speaking after Dr Isaac Opoku, Mr John Darko, Mr Frank Yeboah and Nana Osei-Adjei. So, on our Side, we intend to offload these outstanding names to Tuesday, because Tuesday, we will have Hon Members

speaking before the Leaders would conclude. Having said that, the Leader has given a certain indication of a commemorative Statement, and we have no objection to that; we can take it. Mr Speaker, it is now past 3 p.m. We had originally intended to close early today, because today is Friday, and a number of our Colleagues will also be travelling. So, if we can limit ourselves on the commemorative Statement, I am sure we should be fine.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. We proceed to the item numbered 7, commemorative Statement standing in the name of Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw.

You have the floor.

### **Commemoration of World Fisheries Day, 2025**

**Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw (NDC — Wa East):** Mr Speaker, this is a Statement on World Fisheries Day, which is marked today.

Mr Speaker, I rise with a deep sense of humility and a sense of duty as well to speak on the occasion of World Fisheries Day 2025, under the theme, “Resetting Fisheries: Chief Fishermen and Fishmongers as Guardians and Partners in Sustainable Fisheries Management”. This theme is a call to action, a call to reflection, a call to reimagine the future of our fisheries. It is not just as a sector in crisis, but as a pillar of prosperity, culture and ecological balance.

The day was established in 1998 with the intention of paying tribute to fishers who, through their profession and service, provide valuable contributions to the development of our society.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's fisheries sector is at crossroads. For decades, our coastal and inland waters have nourished our people, sustained livelihoods and anchored our cultural identity. Today, however, we face a stark reality of decline in fish stocks due to overfishing, illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing, degraded marine ecosystems from pollution of mangroves and other ecosystem-related structures. Economic vulnerability among artisanal fishers and fishmongers, especially the women who form the backbone of our post-harvest fisheries activities.

Mr Speaker, if we do not act decisively, we risk not only the collapse of a vital industry, but the erosion of a way of life.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is in a reset phase. In the fisheries sector, “reset” is a call to recalibration of our relationship with our oceans, from one of declining hope and landings to one of stewardship. It means rebuilding fish stocks through science-based management, investing in value addition, cold storage and market access.

Mr Speaker, in every coastal and riparian community, the chief fisherman or headman is more than a leader. He is a living institution. He regulates access to fishing grounds, mediates in disputes, enforces taboos and preserves indigenous knowledge. Yet, in recent years, the

authority of the chief fisherman has been eroded by weak integration into formal governance structures, encroachment by industry trawlers and foreign vessels, and the lack of legal recognition and logistical support.

Mr Speaker, it is time to restore and retool the role of the chief fisherman. Let us codify their roles in fisheries legislation, for they are not relics of the past but vanguards of the future.

Mr Speaker, let us now turn to fishmongers, predominantly women, who process, transport and sell the fish to feed our nation. They are entrepreneurs who sustain our local economies. However, they face limited access to low-cost financing credits, exposure to post-harvest losses, due to a lack of cold chains as well as ready markets.

Mr Speaker, to reset fisheries, we must elevate fishmongers from the margins to the mainstream. This could be achieved by establishing and supporting cooperatives and revolving funds tailored to their needs.

Mr Speaker, I see a deep connection with the envisaged Women's Bank, and I hope that policymakers will take this up and do the right linkages.

Mr Speaker, when we empower fishmongers, we empower families, markets and the nation at large. Mr Speaker, resetting our fisheries requires more than rhetoric. It demands bold policy shifts and institutional reforms. We have a new law, Act 1146. This emphasises aquaculture as well to

supplement the reducing stocks from our oceans. We should operationalise it along the following:

First, promote household aquaculture farms whose operations can be codified and recognises traditional authorities, gender roles and local knowledge.

Second, expand canoe identification monitoring systems so that we do not have overstocking of our waters with so many canoes.

Third, support for establishment of more marine protected areas that can be co-managed by communities and chief fishermen.

Fourth, we should consider integrating climate resilience practices to restore our ecosystems in the fisheries and the oceans.

Last, we should also deliberately promote public-private partnerships to develop fish landing sites, cold storage and value chains.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is being watched. Our actions can inspire other coastal nations. Let us lead by example by honouring our traditional leaders not just in ceremonies but in strategy and in action. Let us listen, let us act, let us reset. Let this World Fisheries Day be remembered not just as a commemoration, but as a turning point. We should consider adapting an integrated multi-sectoral policy framework along these lines.

3:25 p.m.

Let us deliberately strengthen coordination between national and

regional agencies. Let us invest in data systems for evidence-based oversight. Let us ensure broader stakeholder inclusion in our policy processes. Let us reset. Let us rebuild. Let us transform our fishery for transformation. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Statement has been ably made. Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, given the exigencies, we would want to take one on each Side then we will take Leadership to conclude.

**Mr Annoh-Dompreh:** Mr Speaker, we have no objection to that.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Odamtten?

**Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten (NDC — Tema East):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I commend the maker of the Statement. This commemorative Statement has come in time to awaken consciousness for our preparedness towards improving a very important sector of our economy, which is fisheries. For us coastal MPs, we recognise the importance of the fisheries sector in our Ghanaian economy and in our local economic interplay. Many of our people have now bought into the new policy arrangement that seeks to not look at fisheries as an occupation, but one that would look at fisheries as a resource that needs to be attended to for its sustainability, continual support for livelihoods, and the opportunities that we can have today. Both inland and ocean

fisheries have contributed significantly to our Ghanaian economy.

The maker of the Statement highlighted the need for resetting. Mr Speaker, I would want to re-echo that section of the Statement. He makes the point that it is indeed time to reset, and the reset is one that requires us to ensure that we move from a declining hope and landings to one of stewardship. So, it is not just a matter of investing in equipment to go fishing, but it is a matter of doing it sustainably. That is why, even in the face of difficulties for our local fishermen, we have brought to the fore the need for proper fishing gears that would not offend the ecosystem of our ocean and our water bodies.

We have also encouraged our local stakeholders in the fishery sector to appreciate science in modern fisheries. Of course, our traditional leaders and our forebears used traditional means, such as not going fishing on specific days of the week to improve fish stocks. But it has become abundantly clear that that is not enough. So, we have to marry science, which is empirical, with research that helps us to sustain the fish resources.

Mr Speaker, today being National Fisheries Day, we have to commend the Ministry and the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture for highlighting the celebration of the sector. In a very grandiose programme today, we had the reaffirmation of H. E. John Dramani Mahama's support for the sector and the hope that the fishing communities, especially the inland fishing communities and the coastal constituencies have in the

reset agenda. As has been espoused in the debates in previous days, we know the right investments are being made in the agriculture and fishery sector. The aquaculture aspect of our fisheries would also help us to deepen the sustainability of the fish resources of this country. With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Minority Leadership.

**Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh):** Mr Speaker, permit me to commend my very good Friend for bringing this matter up. Oftentimes, we tend to relegate issues concerning the fishing sector to the back burner. I am happy we have our Majority Chief Whip as the chair of the National Premix Fuel Committee, so I know he is going to push in a lot of discipline and sanitise the sector.

But I am particularly happy about the angle of we bringing fishmongers into the governance structure of our country. That, for me, is a crux of the call of Dr Jasaw. It is the area that has eluded us for a very long time. Concerns about inland fishing. I think there are some subtle attempts at fingerlings being given out to women folks and a number of people to help in the group and the rearing of fish. It is good, but the culture has still not caught up well enough. So, there is a lot the Committee Chairman has to do. I am sure this House will be very excited to join forces with him, so that he can leave a very good legacy.

Concerns about illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing has come up

strongly. I recall there was an international instrument we had to ratify which speaks to these concerns, and then eventually the passage of the Bill.

The knowledge and awareness about the importance of mangrove still stands in suspense. Many of us do not even know. In times past when we were growing up in the village, when we saw a mangrove, we were told that it is a place where spirits reside, so we were not supposed to go there. We failed to communicate the scientific importance of mangrove to the environment, community, and especially in rearing of fish. It is a matter that I think the Ministry may have to take up, most importantly.

But in all these, what stands as a yawning concern is sustainable fishing. I am happy the Deputy Minister is here. It cannot be business as usual. So, when we fish as usual, the fishing stock will deplete, and our protein concerns and needs will become a challenge. What do we do? In times past, there have been various interventions where fisherfolks have been stopped from going to the sea for a certain period of time. Has it all really helped ultimately in helping build stock and the development of the fishing industry? These are concerns that we need to look at.

Then again, nature-based solutions. Mr Speaker today, the narrative on sustainability, nature-based solutions feed to the core of it, and these nature-based solutions are unique to various regions of the world. Africa has its own nature-based solution, Europe then Latin

America. What is it that pertains to Africa? For me, that is where I think we should revolve around and help build these matters.

We have heard about premix coming up every now and then as a concern. I hope we will be able to proffer some solutions to give some respite to our fisherfolks. I recall the previous government built a number of—*[Pause]*—automated stations and a number of fishing harbours. But still, our fisherfolks are not happy enough, and this is not politics.

3:35 p.m.

There would be another day when we are considering the Estimates, we would have an opportunity to put matters in context. There is something missing with our fisherfolk because if we go to the coastal areas, the poverty level among other things. Hon Minister, you are here so we should think aloud on this commemorative day on what we can do to help in the alleviation of poverty in this part of our country. But be it a commemorative day, maybe some lessons should be drawn. Going forward, we should not be repeating the same concern. It should be an opportunity for us to relapse and take stock of what we have done as a country and move forward. I particularly want to charge my good Friend, the Chief Whip, that he should leave some good legacies. I know how committed he is and when he is committed to doing something, he gets it done. He can count on me. Even though I will not serve on the Board, I will be behind and give him all the moral support.

Mr Speaker, thank you. Just to end on a note of appeal.

Mr Speaker, I know you are tired. But you are the only one who can do this for us. Hon Vincent had also submitted a Statement. It is rightly captured here.

Mr Speaker, if it pleases you, it is a Statement on boxing, may you do us the honour and the favour so that when we are done with commentaries on this, he could be granted to read his Statement as well. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I am inclined not to accede to that request. Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

**Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor):** Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to add my voice by way of commentary on the Statement ably presented by the Chairman for the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs to commemorate today as World Fisheries Day.

Mr Speaker, as a nation endowed with some of the most notable rivers in the world, about a third of our population survive on these water bodies and the ocean. Primarily, the activities will centre around fishing and water-related activities like farming along the banks of the rivers, as well as aquaculture practices.

Mr Speaker, some 27 years ago, the world saw it fit in 1998 to set this day aside to celebrate people involved in fishing and aquaculture industry. There are some countries like the Scandinavia

and Northern Region of Canada whose economies rely on fishing. So, fishing is big and it is so in Ghana. When we speak of the fishing in the inland along the major water bodies like the Volta Lake, we have over 3 million of our people involved in fishing and aquaculture-related activities. So, for me, regarding the policies we are initiating to fight the *galamsey* menace, I think that if we promote aquaculture, that is, fish farming, it will be the solution to the *galamsey* activities.

Mr Speaker, here is why. If we manufacture a cage 12 by 12 feet and it is populated with 5,000 fingerlings of tilapia, we can harvest in eight weeks, depending on the demand of the market. A kilo of tilapia of four, five inches or six inches is about GH¢50. When you harvest a tilapia 12 by 12 feet, that is about three tonnes. So, the revenue potential of encouraging people to go into fish farming, that is artificial breeding of fish on the freshwater bodies, especially on the Volta Lake, is so huge. It is capable of attracting the youth from engaging in this activity of degrading the environment to look for some gold that we cannot find and it is clean. The practices and the protocols are such that it is clean.

Mr Speaker this is because, you see, the Volta Lake is not stagnant, it flows into the sea. So, even though the lake looks huge, it is flowing imperceptibly but it flows into the sea. So freshwater is always coming from the three major tributaries. It is something we need to look at and from where I sit, we have been discussing that with the Chairman

of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs, as well as the Minister for Food and Agriculture. We have to roll it out deliberately and look at some grants to be able to attract the young people and I am sure that many MPs can also champion this. We have 54 constituencies along the Volta Lake throughout the country and I have started in South Dayi.

Mr Speaker, it may interest you to know that some deliberate policies have also been introduced in the distribution of pre-mix fuel to our farmers, both inland and marine, especially to check the maintenance of diversion. Diversion simply means that the fuel would not get to the community or the people to which it is meant for purposes of their fishing activities or for transportation. By seeking to brand vehicles that will transport the fuel, so that when you see a fuel tanker on the road, you know that this fuel is transporting pre-mix. So, when it is seen in an area where it is not supposed to be, it can be checked. Also, the committees have been revived. Some audits are ongoing. So far, as a committee, we are working effectively. There is no issue about diversion and all that. We also want to encourage the people who are helping the farmers and fishermen to let their businesses to continue to assist them.

Mr Speaker, today, there is a major conference that just ended at the Accra International Conference Centre. It was under the theme, “Resetting Fisheries, Chief Fishermen and Fishmongers as Guardians and Partners in Sustainable Fisheries Management”. Like the Hon

Minority Chief Whip, who indicated, the women folk play a major role—so, when the catch is brought home and it is treated, smoked, preserved, either by freezing it or salting it becomes the duty of the women folk to now take it to the markets or bring it home for consumption. So, their role in the food chain is so important. How are we assisting them? We need to generate a viable industry out of that practise so that they do not look outsourced so they can be promoted to be able to do this.

Mr Speaker, we thank the maker of the Statement for bringing this matter to the attention of the Floor so that we can commemorate this day every year. We also believe that encouraging the young people not to see fishing activities as a backward activity, as an activity abandoned for the downtrodden or people who have no future. This is because in countries like Malaysia, Thailand, Sweden, Norway, Finland, Canada, among others some of the millionaires or billionaires are actually fishermen who are into serious fish farming on land.

Mr Speaker, with these words, I thank the maker of the Statement and we wish our fishermen, fisherfolk and women who are fishmongers the best of the day.

Mr Speaker, some request has been related to you. So, we are entirely in your hands in this matter. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, we have not done five hours, so you may move a Motion for adjournment.

**Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor):** Mr Speaker, with no further Business, I move that the House be adjourned until Tuesday at midday.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Motion moved for Adjournment. Any seconder?

**Minority Chief Whip (Mr Annoh-Dompreh):** Mr Speaker, I rise to second the motion.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.*

## ADJOURNMENT

*The House was accordingly adjourned at 3:46 p.m. till Tuesday, 25<sup>th</sup> November, 2025, at 12 noon.*



## **Editor's Note**

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 3<sup>rd</sup> December, 2025.

Column 9, last paragraph, “Aha”  
was replaced with “Ahafo”